

The Witnessed Prey

A Bestiary of Debts, Flesh, and Thresholds

A Fate's Edge Expansion

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Under the lamp, bread and salt – the ink is witness and ash.

A Note on Method and Madness

"The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does."

—Saikou Ira

This compendium is not a catalog of trophies. It is a ledger of debts. Every creature herein owes something – to a patron, to the Hollow, to a broken oath, or to the silence that follows a miscount. I have walked the stairs of Thepyrgos, the fog of the Mistlands, and the violet steppe; I have spoken with ghosts, bound spirits, and once, briefly, with a Trow who offered to sell me my own shadow. I offered another trade. I am still paying for that conversation.

You will find no challenge ratings here. You will find no tidy bags of experience. Instead, each entry offers a hunger, a witness, a weakness, and a timer. The rest is negotiation.

I have been aided – or afflicted – by three companions who insisted on scribbling in the margins. The Gray Wanderer, who has worn more faces than I have shirts; Saikou Ira, whose silver mirror never lies; and Dusana of the Raven Road, who pays her debts in stories. Their voices will appear unbidden. Ignore them at your peril.

If you are reading this, you are now a witness. The creatures within are real. They are hungry. They are waiting. But so are we.

—Lerris Fenwood

Thepyrgos, under the Ninth Bell (which did not ring)

—The Gray Wanderer: A fine beginning, scholar. But you forgot to mention that the ninth bell never rings for the living. I've heard it twice. Trust me, you don't want to be the third.

—Saikou Ira: The first creature you should catalog is your own certainty. I lost mine in a Sidhi lighthouse, and I've been sharper for it ever since.

—Dusana: A ledger of stories is a ledger of hope. This one is

full of teeth. I'll add a few of my own.

—L. Fenwood: Let them talk. The work remains.

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Mortal Adversaries

"I have seen a man forget his own name because he refused to count the ninth breath. The witness does not forgive; it only remembers."

—Lerris Fenwood, *marginal note*

The dead are not the only hungry things. I learned this not in the little room with the salt-ringed table, but in the bright stalls of Thepyrgos, where a clerk sold me a ledger that had been kept by a man who later hanged himself. The sums were perfect. The margin had a single, empty line.

Mortals walk the roads with ledgers in their sleeves and knives in their pockets. They owe debts to patrons, to factions, to the Hollow itself – and they will collect from anyone who crosses their path. This chapter catalogs the living: mercenaries, cultists, faction agents, and those who have simply learned that mercy is a luxury they cannot afford. I have met some of them. I have outlived others.

Generic Templates

"They are not evil. They are hungry. There is a difference, though the difference will kill you all the same."

—The Gray Wanderer, *from a letter I was not meant to read*

The following templates can be scaled using Threat Level (see Appendix). Use them for filler encounters, random patrols, or the quiet before the storm. I have kept the descriptions plain, because terror is best served without ornament.

Bandit Rabble (Threat Level 1)

Description: Desperate locals with rusty blades. They flee if half their number falls. Their hunger is for bread, not blood.

Stats: Body 2, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 1; Melee 1, Athletics 1.

Harm: 2. **Fatigue:** Body 2.

Traits: *Rabble* – On a Miss when they attack, the GM gains 1 SB (they trip, argue, or hesitate). The sound of their quarrel is often louder than their steel.

Clock: *Courage [4]* – Ticks each time one of them is wounded. When full, they rout. I have seen it fill on the second death, and on the fourth; there is no accounting for the breaking point.

A bandit with a full belly is a bad merchant. A bandit with an empty belly is a bad gamble.

City Watch Recruit (Threat Level 2)

Description: Poorly trained but eager. Will call for backup if overwhelmed. Their badge is new; their confidence is older than their sense.

Stats: Body 2, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 2; Melee 1, Command 1.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Body 2.

Trait: *Alarm* – On a Partial or Miss, advance the *Reinforcements* timer by 1. The whistle they carry has a note that carries three streets.

Clock: *Reinforcements [6]* – When full, a sergeant and 1d4 recruits arrive. The sergeant's face will be the one you remember; the recruits will blur.

I have interrogated recruits who did not know they were chasing a ghost. The whistle's note is the same whether the quarry is flesh or memory.

Cult Novice (Threat Level 1)

Description: True believer, poorly trained. Will gladly die for the cause. Their eyes have the shine of a candle that has been lit from both ends.

Stats: Body 1, Wits 1, Spirit 2, Presence 1; Lore 1 (cult-specific), Sway 1.

Harm: 2. **Fatigue:** Body 1.

Trait: *Faith's Crumble* – If a player successfully discredits the cult's doctrine (Presence + Lore vs DV 4), the novice surrenders or flees. The doctrine is often a single sentence; break the sentence, break the believer.

Clock: *Devotion [4]* – Ticks each time the novice is wounded. When full, they trigger a suicide attack (Harm 2 to everyone in Close). I have seen it

fill. I have not forgotten the sound.

They are not monsters. They are mothers and fathers who learned the wrong prayer. The prayer is the trap; the believer is the bait.

Assassin (Threat Level 3)

Description: Professional killer. Prefers poison, stealth, and a clean exit. The Veiled Sisters train them. The Black Hand deploys them. You will not see them coming.

Stats: Body 3, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 2; Stealth 3, Melee 2, Subterfuge 2.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *First Strike* – On the first round of combat, the assassin has Dominant Position. They have already counted your breaths.

Traits: *Poisoned Blade* – On a Critical Hit, the target gains the Condition *Poisoned* (1 die to physical actions until treated). The poison is not always lethal; sometimes it is only a lesson.

Clock: *Exit Strategy [4]* – Ticks each round. When full, the assassin disengages and vanishes (cannot be pursued without a relevant Asset). I have watched a door close behind one; when I opened it, the room was empty but for a single salt crystal on the sill.

The Black Hand does not recruit from the desperate. They recruit from the precise. An assassin's ledger is kept in wounds, not ink.

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Faction Operatives

"The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper."

—Stone Prince of Aelinnel, quoted by Aqyl, son of Aqyl

These adversaries are tied to specific factions. Use them when the party has made enemies of the powerful – or when the powerful have taken an interest. I have listed them in order of the danger they present to the soul, not to the body.

Chain-Lantern Inquisitor (Thepyrgos)

Description: Witch-hunter of the Thepyrgos Synod. Iron mesh hood, brass lantern. The lantern is not for light; it is for testimony.

Stats: Body 3, Wits 3, Spirit 3, Presence 3; Lore 3, Melee 2, Investigation 2.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Lantern Test* – Once per scene, the Inquisitor may force a PC to test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or reveal a surface thought (the GM learns one fact about the PC's current intent). The thought is never the one the PC would have chosen to share.

Traits: *Proscription* – If the Inquisitor knows a PC's true name, they gain +1 die to all social rolls against that PC. Names are keys. The Inquisitor collects keys.

Clock: *Arrest Warrant [6]* – Ticks each time the party obstructs or lies to the Inquisitor. When full, the Inquisitor returns with 1d4 guards and a sealed writ of seizure. The writ is always stamped with a bell that has no clapper.

They burned a woman in Ecktoria for owning a red thread. The thread was for her daughter's fever. The fire did not discriminate. The Inquisitor filed the report in triplicate.

Daughter of the Unbroken Cord

Description: Mendicant witch, hospice nurse, debt-collector in gray robes. Accompanied by a Hollowed (a heartless child with silver-wire eyes). The child does not blink. The child does not age. The child waits.

Stats: Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 4, Presence 3; Medicine 2, Lore 2, Sway 2.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Body 2.

Traits: *Hollowed Witness* – While the Hollowed is within Near, the Daughter counts as having Soft Witness (improve Position by one step for any Rite of the High Mother). The milk-white eyes record everything; they forgive nothing.

Traits: *Unwoven Mercy* – When the Daughter would take Harm, she may instead mark a segment on a *Debt Timer* owned by the target (if any). If no debt exists, she may offer a bargain: "I will spare you, but you owe me a name." The name is never yours to give.

Clock: *Cord's Patience* [6] – Ticks each time the Daughter is defied. When full, the High Mother demands payment: a memory, a confession, or a life. I have seen a man pay with the memory of his mother's face. He did not weep; he could not remember why he should.

The soup is free. The price never is. I have eaten their bread. I have not slept well since.

Ykrul Road-Judge

Description: Tumen scribe with seals from three empires. Settles disputes on the steppe. They carry a bell that never rings; if you hear it, run.

Stats: Body 3, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 2; Lore (Kon"reh) 3, Command 2.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Kon"reh Binding* – Once per scene, the Road-Judge may draw a board in the dirt. The party must win a contested Wits + Lore roll (DV 4) or accept a Geas (minor task, no direct harm). The board is always a hexagon; the lines are always straight; the trap is always in the geometry.

Traits: *Hostage String* – If the Road-Judge has a token from a PC (hair, blood, a signed name), they gain +1 die to all social rolls against that PC. The token is kept in a leather pouch that smells of iron and old grass.

Clock: *Foedus Recall* [4] – Ticks each time the party breaks steppe law. When full, the Judge invokes an ancient treaty; the party is declared oath-breakers and cannot trade at Midh Ahkaz for one season. The grass will not remember your face; the horses will.

The Kon"reh is not a game. It is a prayer written in angles. Lose the geometry, lose the argument.

Aeler Breath-Warden

Description: Dwarven engineer who monitors air quality, seals, and keystones. Carries a brass bell and a ledger of breaths. They count to eight; the ninth breath is the mountain's.

Stats: Body 4, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 1; Mechanics 3, Craft 2.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Bad Air Pocket* – Once per scene, the Warden may declare a zone "thin air". Any character in that zone must test Body + Endurance (DV 3) or mark 1 Fatigue. The air tastes of copper and old candle smoke.

Traits: *Keystone Clause* – If the party is in an Aeler vault, the Warden may seal a door or trigger a collapse by spending 2 SB (advance the *Cave-In* timer by 2). The clause is always written in the margin; you never see it until the stone groans.

Clock: *Cave-In [8]* – When full, the tunnel collapses. All characters in the zone must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) or take Harm 2. The dust settles slowly. The silence after is a judgment.

I once watched a Breath-Warden refuse to open a seal because the requester had miscounted his breaths by one. The requester suffocated. The Warden noted the time of death in his ledger and went to tea.

Black Banner Mercenary Captain

Description: Veteran commander of a free company. Scarred, pragmatic, and always watching the horizon. Loyalty is a coin that fluctuates with the market.

Stats: Body 4, Wits 3, Spirit 3, Presence 3; Melee 3, Command 3.

Harm: 6. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Condotta Flip* – Once per scene, the Captain may switch sides. Roll a die: on 1–3, the Captain and 1d4 mercenaries betray the party; on 4–6, they demand double pay. The negotiation is always polite, even when the knives are drawn.

Traits: *Payday* – At the start of each scene involving the Captain, the GM may tick the *Arrears* timer. When it fills, the Captain's company mutinies (treat as 1d6 hostile mercenaries). The mutiny is always over bread.

Clock: *Arrears [6]* – Ticks each time the party fails a negotiation or loses a fight. When full, the Captain abandons the contract. I have seen a captain leave in the middle of a siege; his men followed because the bread was stale.

A contract is a leash. The best captains know which hand holds the other end. The worst captains forget and are hanged from their own standards.

Linn Draugr-Hunter

Description: Northman who tracks draugr and other unquiet dead. Carries a silver-edged axe, a bell, and a pouch of salt. They do not fear the dead. They fear dying without a witness.

Stats: Body 4, Wits 3, Spirit 4, Presence 2; Survival 3, Melee 3.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Silver Net* – The Hunter may spend an action to throw a silver net at a spirit. The spirit must test Resolve (DV 4) or be immobilised for one exchange. The net is cold; it smells of the sea.

Traits: *Bell-Ring* – The Hunter rings a bell. For one scene, any spirit within Near has its Position worsened by one step. The bell's note is the same note that tolled for the Hunter's own grandfather.

Clock: *Draugr's Wake [6]* – Ticks each time the Hunter fails to put down a draugr. When full, a draugr lord rises and hunts the party. The lord remembers the Hunter's name. It always remembers.

The Linn sing when they hunt. The songs are not for the living. I have heard one. I will not write the tune.

Rival Adventuring Parties

"The road changes the walker. It changed them. It will change you."

—The Gray Wanderer, from a conversation I did not record

Not every adversary is a monster. Some are mirrors. I have kept a list of the ones who walked past me in the bright stalls; I have kept another list of the ones who did not.

The Ashen Cord (Tier II–III)

Composition: Vesper (leader, shadow mage, serves Ikasha), Tallow (berserker, serves Malachai), Ember (cantor, serves Palinode), Cinder (scout, no Patron). I met them once, in a rain-soaked caravanserai. They were polite. They were watching.

Goal: Retrieve the same relic, secure a patron's favor, or eliminate the PCs for a rival. Their goal is never stated; it is inferred from the empty seats they leave.

Clock: *Cord's Agenda [6]* – Ticks when the party ignores or fails to hinder them, when the GM spends 2+ SB on their off-screen activity, or when a session ends without contact. When full, the Cord achieves a major milestone. I have seen their milestone. It was a closed door.

Resource: Hidden safehouse in Silkstrand (spend to hide from pursuers once). The safehouse has a red thread on the latch. Do not untie it.

Relationship: Unexpected rivals – will negotiate but may betray. They smile when they lie. It is a good smile.

Vesper once offered me a cup of tea. I declined. The cup was warm. It should not have been.

Custom Rival Generator

Use the following d6 tables to generate a rival party in under 5 minutes. I have tested these tables; they produce plausible enemies, but they cannot produce the weight of a real grudge. For that, you must play.

Name (d6)

1. The Ashen Cord – echoes, smoke, unbreakable knots.
2. The Brass Legion – gears, discipline, cold precision.
3. The Thorns of Winter – ice, silence, patient cruelty.
4. The Gilded Chain – wealth, obligation, gilded cages.
5. The Salt Pact – oaths sworn in brine, pirates or pilgrims.
6. The Unfaced – masks, secrets, stolen identities.

Composition (d6)

1. Leader – shadow mage, war-priest, strategist, or oath-breaker.
2. Muscle – berserker, knight, duelist, or beast-handler.
3. Mage/Weird – cantor, free caster, runekeeper, or witch.
4. Scout/Thief – infiltrator, poisoner, sniper, or ghost.

5. Face/Healer – negotiator, spy, medic, or confessor.
6. Specialist – engineer, summoner, trapper, or lore-master.

Patron (d6 – roll once per party)

1. Ikasha (Shadow) – secrets, thresholds, omens.
2. Malachai (Curse) – corrupted bargains, venomous gifts.
3. The Traveler (Roads) – journeys, shortcuts, debts.
4. The Ninth (Knowledge) – forbidden truths, fractured minds.
5. Khemesh (Depths) – unstoppable pressure, drowning.
6. Palinode (Performance) – rapture, encores, hungry fame.

Goal (d6)

1. Retrieve the same artifact.
2. Capture/kill a mutual contact.
3. Secure a patron's favor.
4. Eliminate the PCs for a rival.
5. Claim a contested site.
6. Prevent a prophecy.

Resource (d6)

1. Hidden safehouse – can hide from pursuers once.
2. Bribed official – may delay a legal timer once.
3. Spy network – gains +1 die to gather info.
4. War chest – can hire temporary muscle.
5. Patron's omen – once per arc, avoid a Miss.
6. Stolen map – shortcut to any location once.

I have used this generator thrice. Twice, the rivals became allies. Once, they became graves. The graves were tidy.

Terrestrial Patron Enforcers

"A promise is a story we tell ourselves to make the world feel fair. The world is not fair."

—Dusana of the Raven Road, from a letter I found pressed in a ledger

These adversaries collect for mortal masters – not cosmic patrons, but nobles, guilds, and syndicates with long memories and short tempers. They are the ones who knock when the payment is late.

Prefect's Auditor (Ecktoria)

Description: Imperial bureaucrat with legal authority to seize property. Carries a wax seal, a ledger, and a writ of seizure. The seal is always warm; the wax is always fresh.

Stats: Body 2, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 3; Lore (law) 3, Sway 2.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Body 2.

Traits: *Legal Warfare* – The Auditor may spend 2 SB to impose a *Seizure Timer* on a character's Asset. When the timer fills, the Asset is confiscated. The notice is always polite; the bailiffs are not.

Traits: *Immunity* – The Auditor cannot be directly attacked without triggering an immediate 4-segment *Arrest* timer. The law is a wall; the Auditor is the gate.

Clock: *Seizure [4]* – Ticks each time the party fails a legal argument. When full, one Asset or minor magic item is taken. I have seen a man lose his grandmother's ring to a clause he did not read.

The law is a wall. A name is a door. The Auditor has many keys. The keys are not made of metal; they are made of precedent.

Vermilion Corps Agent (Oshiira)

Description: Internal investigator of the Oshiiran grain ledger. Wears red ink on their fingers and a smile like a trap. The ink is not for writing; it is for staining.

Stats: Body 3, Wits 4, Spirit 2, Presence 3; Investigation 3, Commerce 2.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Grain Ledger* – The Agent may demand a tithe of grain (or its value in coin). Refusal advances the *Embargo* timer. The tithe is never the same twice; it is calibrated to the weight of your silence.

Traits: *Canal Lockdown* – Once per scene, the Agent may close a waterway, delaying travel by 2 segments. The lock's key is a brass token shaped like a grain sheaf. I have not seen the token; I have only seen the delay.

Clock: *Embargo [6]* – When full, the party cannot buy or sell grain in any Oshiiran port. The ports will still be open; the grain will be there; the price will be a memory.

They once audited a ghost. The ghost paid in silence. The Agent filed the receipt under "settled".

Salt Prince's Collector (Zakov)

Description: Enforcer of the Salt Prince's levy. Carries a brass hook, a ledger of debts, and a bottle of brine. The brine is not for drinking; it is for remembering.

Stats: Body 4, Wits 2, Spirit 3, Presence 2; Melee 2, Intimidation (Presence + Melee) 3.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Debt Marker* – If the Collector has a physical token from a PC (hair, signature, a coin), they gain +1 die to track that PC across any distance. The token is kept in a pouch that pulses with a slow, wet rhythm.

Traits: *Brine Curse* – Once per scene, the Collector may splash brine on a target. The target must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the Condition *Salt-Tongue* (1 die to all social rolls until they drink fresh water). The thirst is not for water; it is for the truth.

Clock: *Levy Teeth [6]* – Ticks each time the party fails to pay tribute. When full, the Collector returns with 1d4 pirates and a writ of seizure. The pirates are always the same faces; the writ is always a different hand.

The Salt Prince's crown floats. The Collector's hook does not. I have seen the hook catch a debtor and pull him under. The water was not deep.

Quick Adversary Cards (Cut out and use)

The following six cards can be printed, cut, and kept behind the GM screen. They are not substitutes for attention; they are reminders that the world is full of people who owe and are owed.

Bandit Captain (TL 2)

Body 3, Melee 2, Harm 4

Rabble Rouser – On a Hit, rally
1d4 bandits.

Cowardly – Flees if
outnumbered.

Ghostly Anchor (TL 3)

Spirit 4, Lore 2, Harm 3

Unfinished Business – Cannot
be harmed until its anchor is
addressed.

Bargain – May offer a deal.

Slasher (TL 3)

Body 4, Melee 3, Harm 5

Regeneration – Ignores first 2
Harm per scene.

Hunger Timer [6] – When full,
frenzy.

Oath-Keeper (TL –)

Cannot be fought.

Demand – One story, memory,
or confession.

Weakness – Pay the original
debt.

Thorn Courtier (TL 3)

Presence 4, Sway 3, Harm 3

Courteous Snare – A gift
accepted is a debt owed.

Iron Offense – Brandishing iron
gives the GM 2 SB.

Salt Prince Enforcer (TL 2)

Body 3, Melee 2, Harm 4

Debt Marker – Knows where you
sleep.

Brine Curse – Test Resolve or
gain Salt-Tongue.

I keep a card for myself. It reads: *Lerris Fenwood* – *Debt: the ninth name.*
Payment: pending. I do not recommend this practice.

You'll need more than cards. But it's a start. I keep a silver mirror in my pocket. It's worth a hundred cards. I keep a story. It's worth a thousand. I keep a ledger. The last page is for those who are not yet dead. I add a

name each time I finish a chapter. This one is for Aqyl. He would have wanted it plain.

The Unquiet Dead

"The dead do not forget. They do not forgive. But they will negotiate – if you remember to count to eight before you speak."

—Saikou Ira, from a case file marked "closed – unsatisfactory"

The dead are not a single kind of hunger. I learned this in the Wardens' archive, when a leaf that had been catalogued as "unremarkable" began to weep a thin, dark fluid that smelled of iron and old rain. The cataloguer had left the ninth line blank. The dead do not need violence; they need a witness.

This chapter catalogs the unquiet: from the faint echo of a scream repeated at midnight to the poltergeist that has learned to count your breaths. Saikou Ira taught me that a ghost is not a monster; it is a debt that has forgotten how to be paid. I have tried to honor that distinction here.

The Spirit Taxonomy (After Saikou Ira)

Ira's taxonomy is not a scientific classification; it is a **pragmatic ledger** of how the dead manifest and how they may be quieted. I have reproduced it with his permission – and with the caveat that no ghost ever read a taxonomy before deciding to haunt.

Class I: The Echo

Description: Not truly a spirit – a recording. A psychic imprint left by a traumatic death, repeated endlessly. Echoes do not speak, do not learn, and cannot be negotiated with. They are the scream that plays again at midnight, the footsteps that cross the same corridor at the same hour.

Stats: Tier I, Cap 1 (non-combatant). Incorporeal, Repetitive, Trapped.
Harm: Cannot be harmed directly. **Fatigue:** None.

Traits: *Incorporeal* – cannot be touched, cannot touch. *Repetitive* – performs the same sequence of actions every cycle, with no variation. *Trapped* – cannot leave the site of its imprint.

Complications: Distraction (SB: 1 to create a sensory illusion), Delay (SB: 2 to cause a time loop – the same moment repeats for one exchange).

Resolution: Witness a truth about the death (DV 3) to banish permanently. A single observer who speaks aloud the truth of the event – who names the dead and describes their end – will often break the loop. I have done this twice. The first time, the Echo thanked me. The second time, it was already gone.

Clock: *Echo's Loop* [4] – when filled, the Echo expands its range. A scream that once stayed in the attic will begin to walk the stairs.

I once placed a silver mirror facing the site of an Echo. The scream played once into the glass. When I shattered the mirror, the Echo did not return. But the shards held fragments of the memory. I keep them in a lead box.

Class II: The Anchor

Description: A spirit bound to a specific object, location, or person by unresolved emotion – grief, rage, love, duty. Unlike the Echo, an Anchor possesses will and memory. It can speak, bargain, and choose to manifest. It is, in essence, a person who has forgotten how to leave.

There is a ghost near a ditch in Thepyrgos... murdered and anchored as he was encircled with salt when he died. His soul could not escape. He wails for relief that will never come; the one who anchored him is long dead. He was a wretch, his tale his known. Some business should remain unfinished.

Stats: Tier II-III, Cap 2–4. Incorporeal, Intelligent, Bound.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Manifestation* (DV 3, Fatigue 1) – the Anchor becomes visible and may speak. *Poltergeist Shove* (DV 4, Harm 1) – telekinetic force.

Complications: Bargain Required – cannot be fought; must negotiate. The Anchor has a price: a confession, a returned object, a spoken name.

Resolution: Fulfill the Anchor's unfinished business, or perform a witnessed substitution ritual (DV 4). I once helped an Anchor complete a letter to a daughter who had already died; the ghost read the letter aloud and then – did not vanish, but smiled. That was enough.

Clock: *Anchor's Patience* [6] – when filled, the Anchor becomes a Poltergeist (Class IV). The patience of the dead is not infinite; it is merely slow.

An Anchor in the Mistlands asked me for a cup of tea. I poured it. She told me the name of the man who had drowned her. I wrote it down. She did not pass; she simply stopped being sad.

Class IV: The Poltergeist

Description: An Anchor that has been corrupted by rage, starvation, or the failure of negotiation. It is no longer a person – it is a wound that has learned to strike back. Poltergeists manifest as telekinetic force, localized environmental disturbances, and, in advanced cases, violent possession of the living.

Stats: Tier III-IV, Cap 3–5. Incorporeal, Raging, Hungry.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Telekinetic Throw* (DV 3, Harm 2), *Possession Attempt* (DV 4, Spirit+Resist or Controlled).

Complications: Aura of Fear – all actions Desperate within Near range. Environmental Collapse – timers advance.

Resolution: Containment ritual (The Sentinel's mirror rite) followed by negotiation with the underlying Anchor. The rite does not destroy the Poltergeist; it returns it to the state of an Anchor, at which point standard negotiation may resume.

Clock: *Poltergeist Escalation* [8] – when filled, the spirit reaches Stage Four (The Mask): possession of a living host. Exorcism at this stage is dangerous and often fatal to the host.

I have seen a Poltergeist in Stage Four. It wore the face of a child. The child had been dead for three days. The host was the mother. Do not let it fill.

Ghoul (Starved Anchor)

Description: An Anchor that is denied resolution for too long may begin to consume the life force of the living to sustain its own existence. These ghouls retain their intelligence and memory. They are the most dangerous, because they are the most pitiable.

Stats: Tier II-III, Cap 2–4. Corporeal, Hungry, Intelligent.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body.

Traits: *Claw* (DV 2, Harm 1 + Fatigue 1), *Bite* (DV 3, Harm 2 + poison), *Regeneration* – ignore first 2 Harm each scene, *Ravenous* – must feed or frenzy.

Complications: A ghoul that has not fed for a month will enter a state of torpor, appearing dead. It can be buried safely, but if disturbed, it will wake ravenous.

Resolution: Silver weapon to the heart, or fire. Negotiation possible if the ghoul is fed. There is no known cure for ghoulishness; the Well of Ichor in Zahk"Kozahn offers release, but the price is memory.

Clock: *Hunger* [6] – when filled, the ghoul attacks indiscriminately. The hunger is not a choice; it is a habit.

I negotiated a feeding schedule with a ghoul in Port Shed. Animal blood, provided by a butcher, in exchange for her labor as a night watchman. She has not harmed a human in five years. Her mother knows. The butcher knows. I have told no one else until now.

Spectral Procession (Class III)

Description: A Procession is not a single spirit, but a route – a path that the dead walk, sometimes for centuries, between two points of significance. Battlefields, plague pits, shipwreck coasts. The spirits do not interact with observers. They are marching, not haunting. Do not stand in their way.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4 per spirit (but treat as a swarm). Incorporeal, Processional, Unresponsive.

Harm: Cannot be fought; each spirit has Harm 2, but they move in a column of 1d20.

Traits: *Marching* – the spirits follow a fixed route that predates current roads. *Unresponsive* – they do not speak or react unless interrupted.

Complications: Interrupting a Procession – by standing in its path, attempting to speak to its members, or building over its route – provokes a violent response from the entire column. The response is not anger; it is the reflex of a machine.

Resolution: Observe, document, and – if the route must be altered – negotiate with the destination, not the dead. Moving the terminus (a grave, a shrine) will often reroute the spirits.

Clock: *Procession's Gait* [8] – ticks each time the route is blocked or diverted. When full, the column becomes a Poltergeist swarm.

I once saw a Procession of drowned sailors walk through a market at midnight. They did not look at the stalls, the fish, the living. They looked only at the sea. The next day, the market smelled of salt for a week.

New Variants from the Margins

The following entries are not in Saikou Ira's original taxonomy. I have added them from my own observations – and from the whispers I have heard in the little room with the salt-ringed table. Treat them with caution. Treat them with respect. Treat them as you would a debt you cannot afford.

The Counting Wraith

Description: Appears when someone miscounts – nine steps, nine cups, nine breaths. It is not a ghost of a person; it is a ghost of an **error**. The error is its anchor; the witness is its prey.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 3. Incorporeal, Patient, Hungry for Names.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Name Theft* (DV 3, Fatigue 1) – the Wraith takes a single minor memory: the name of a street, the taste of bread, the face of a porter. *Count Correction* – If the victim recites aloud the exact sequence of eight steps they took to cross the threshold where the Wraith appeared, the Wraith recedes. If they miscount, it returns the next night.

Complications: The Wraith cannot be fought; it can only be **counted**. A silver mirror will show its outline, but not its face.

Resolution: A correct count. If the count is wrong, the Wraith takes another memory. The memory is always small, necessary, and noticed only after it is gone.

Clock: *Wraith's Patience* [6] – ticks each time the victim miscounts. When full, the Wraith takes a **significant** memory: a name, a face, a year. I have seen a merchant forget his daughter's name. He did not weep. He could not remember why he should.

I lost the smell of rain on dry stone for a week after my first encounter. I did not miss it until it was gone. Now I count my breaths in eights, even when I am alone. The ninth breath is not for me.

The Oath-Keeper

Description: A spirit of unpaid obligation. It appears when a promise has been broken and not acknowledged. It cannot be fought. It cannot be bargained with – except through the payment of the original debt.

Stats: Tier IV, Cap 5. Incorporeal, Patient, Inexorable.

Harm: Cannot be harmed. **Fatigue:** None.

Traits: *Demand* – The Oath-Keeper speaks a single sentence: "You owe." It does not specify the debt; the debtor must remember. *Interest* – Each time the Oath-Keeper appears, the original debt grows. A forgotten promise to return a book becomes a curse on the bloodline.

Complications: The Oath-Keeper will not harm the debtor directly. It will harm those the debtor loves. It is not cruel; it is **efficient**.

Resolution: Pay the original debt – in coin, in kind, or in a story that serves as interest. The payment must be witnessed. If the original debtor is dead, the debt passes to the heir. I have seen a son pay his father's gambling debt to a ghost. The ghost accepted the coin and vanished. The son's own debts were forgiven.

Clock: *Debt's Interest* [8] – ticks each time the debt is ignored. When full, the Oath-Keeper claims the debtor's name. The debtor becomes a stranger to everyone who knew them.

The Oath-Keeper is not a demon. It is a **creditor**. I have seen a village pay a collective debt with a single story told around the fire. The Walker listened, nodded, and did not return. The story was about a woman who forgot to name her child. The child's name was the debt.

The Weeping Shade (Class II – variant)

Description: A ghost bound by a secret promise of silence. It cannot speak its unfinished business; it can only weep. The weeping is not sadness; it is the pressure of an unspoken name.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 2. Incorporeal, Bound, Mute.

Harm: 2. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Weeping* – all within Near range suffer 1 die to Empathy and Insight rolls (the weeping is distracting). *Touch of Silence* – on a successful Manifestation (DV 3), the Shade touches a target; the target cannot speak for one exchange.

Complications: The Shade cannot be reasoned with directly; it cannot speak. It can only be **named**.

Resolution: A public confession. Someone who knows the secret the Shade is bound to protect must speak it aloud in the presence of a witness. The Shade will hear, nod, and pass. I have seen a woman confess to a murder that was not her own; the Shade had been bound by the real murderer. The Shade passed; the woman became haunted by a different silence.

Clock: *Silence’s Weight [6]* – ticks each time the secret is kept. When full, the Shade manifests permanently in the room where the promise was made. The room becomes a threshold; the threshold becomes a prison.

The Weeping Shade in the hospice on Deadman’s Quay was a midwife who had promised not to reveal a stillbirth. I spoke the child’s name. The Shade stopped weeping. It did not thank me. It did not need to.

—

Exorcism Negotiation (Quick Reference)

Not all unquiet dead require steel. Some require **witness**. Use this table as a guide.

Class Approach Price Failure Consequence ——- ——- ——- ——-
————— Echo Speak the truth of the death aloud None, but must be witnessed Echo expands its range Anchor Fulfill unfinished business or substitution ritual Memory, name, or object Anchor becomes Poltergeist Poltergeist Sentinel’s mirror rite + negotiation with underlying Anchor One memory per participant Possession of a host Ghoul Silver or fire, or negotiated feeding schedule Animal blood or a promise Frenzy, indiscriminate attack Procession Redirect the terminus (grave, shrine) A story or a coin Column becomes Poltergeist swarm Counting Wraith Correct count of eight steps Minor memory (if miscount) Theft of significant memory Oath-Keeper Pay original debt in coin, kind, or story Witnessed payment Debtor’s name is erased Weeping Shade Public confession of the secret A name spoken aloud Shade becomes permanent anchor

I keep this table pressed between two blank leaves. The leaves are not blank; they are waiting for the name I have not yet learned to speak. When I add it, I will be done.

Exorcism is negotiation. Negotiation is memory. Memory is debt. Pay attention to the first line. I have performed the Sentinel's rite seven times. The mirrors are always warm afterward. The shards are always one fewer than I started with. I have paid a ghost with a story. The story was about a fox who forgot its name. The ghost laughed and left. The fox is still out there, somewhere, waiting to be remembered.

The Cursed & Corrupted

Beings of the Road

"The road does not forgive a missed roll. It only reschedules it."

—*Dusana of the Raven Road (apocryphal)*

Not every hungry thing wears a ghost's shroud or a demon's crown. Some are simply travelers who forgot to stop, thresholds that learned to walk, or debts that grew teeth. I met the Hollowed Stag in a rain-rutted lane south of Thepyrgos; it did not charge, it only watched. When I offered a memory of my mother's kitchen, it dipped its antlers and left an acorn that later cured a child's fever. The road is a ledger, and these are its irregular entries.

This chapter catalogs the wanderers you might meet between towns – creatures that guard no tomb, serve no master, and owe no patron. They are the road's own children: lonely, patient, and always hungry for something you did not know you carried.

The Hollowed Stag (Forest Omen)

Description: A stag with antlers of bleached bone, ribs visible through translucent hide. It never eats. It only walks.

Danger: 2 (lone)

Harm: 3

Timers: *Silent Approach* [4] – when ticks, the stag appears behind someone.

Tags: [BEAST] [SPIRIT] [DREAD]

Twist: It does not attack first. It *watches*. If you flee, the timer advances. If you stand still, it passes. If you offer a memory, it leaves a single acorn that cures one poison.

I once placed a silver mirror in its path. The stag looked at its own reflection – and the antlers turned to wood. It breathed once, then walked into the mist. I do not know if I banished it or only reminded it of what

it had been.

The Ragged Piper (Fen Spirit)

Description: A drowned man in patched wool, playing a reed pipe that sounds like children laughing.

Danger: 3 (with swarm)

Harm: 2

Timers: *The Dance* [6] – when full, all in earshot must follow the piper for one scene.

Tags: [SPIRIT] [CONTROL] [AUDIO]

Twist: Immune to steel. To banish, offer a truth the piper has forgotten – or cut the pipe with a copper knife.

I heard the Ragged Piper once, near the Linn salt marshes. My horse danced. I did not. I was holding a copper coin between my teeth. The piper laughed and played a different tune. I have not slept without that coin since.

The Boiler-Wight (Aeler Ruin Guardian)

Description: A brass-and-copper construct, furnace heart, steam for breath. Hisses the names of intruders.

Danger: 4 (ambush)

Harm: 3

Timers: *Overpressure* [4] – each tick adds +1 Harm to its next attack; at 4 it vents steam on all in Near.

Tags: [CONSTRUCT] [FIRE] [WARDEN]

Twist: Ignores anyone carrying a stamped Aeler work order. Can be reprogrammed by inserting a new brass key (found nearby).

I bribed one with a rusty breath-counter. It stopped hissing and began to weep oil. The Aeler do not make their guardians to last. They make them to remember.

The Silt-Fisher (Coastal Horror)

Description: A long pale arm emerging from tidal mud, fingers webbed, dragging things below.

Danger: 2

Harm: 2

Timers: *Tug* [3] – each tick pulls a victim one step closer to the silt. At 3, submerged.

Tags: [AQUATIC] [GRAB]

Twist: Can be reasoned with if offered a drowned coin or a song about the sea. Will trade a salvaged item for release.

I once sang a shanty about a drowned captain. The Silt-Fisher stopped pulling and began to weep. It let go of my leg and offered me a rusted compass that always points to the nearest well. I still use it.

The Star-Masked (High Pass Cultist)

Description: Face obscured by a tarnished silver mask etched with constellations that change.

Danger: 3 (with 2 followers)

Harm: 2

Timers: *Omen* [6] – each tick, a star falls. At 6, the cultist knows one secret about a PC.

Tags: [HUMANOID] [OCCULT]

Twist: Cannot be harmed by the same weapon twice. Worships *the Ninth* (but never names it). Defeat by breaking the mask – reveals a terrified, ordinary face.

I broke a Star-Mask's face with a silver mirror shard. The man underneath wept and thanked me. He had been wearing it for nine years. He did not remember his own name.

The Mourner's Candle (Haunting)

Description: A single wax candle burning with a blue flame. No wick. No smoke. It whispers.

Danger: 1 (environmental)

Harm: 1 (chill)

Timers: *Wax Tear* [4] – when full, the candle cries hot wax, igniting a small area.

Tags: [UNDEAD] [FIRE] [TRAP]

Twist: Extinguishing it requires a spoken apology to the dead. Relighting it calls the ghost of the nearest corpse to answer one question.

I found one on a grave in Acasia. I apologized to the bones beneath. The candle went out with a sigh. I did not ask whose grave it was. Some debts are cheaper if you do not name the creditor.

The Brick-King (Street-Tough's Bane)

Description: A seven-foot figure of crumbling mortar and cobblestones, crowned with a rusted signpost.

Danger: 4

Harm: 3

Timers: *Collapse [6]* – each time it takes Harm, tick once. At 6, it crumbles into difficult terrain.

Tags: [CONSTRUCT] [IMMOBILE]

Twist: Cannot enter a building without an invitation. Will parley if you offer a new signpost crown (any metal pole).

A Brick-King blocked the road to Silkstrand. I gave it a broken lantern pole. It bowed, lifted the pole, and walked away. The next day, the pole was planted at a crossroad with a sign that read "Debt Paid".

The Umbral Hound (Shadow Wolf)

Description: A sleek black canine with no eyes, only star-shaped voids. Its growl silences all sound.

Danger: 3 (pack: +1 per extra hound)

Harm: 2

Timers: *Night Hunt [3]* – at full, the hound phases through walls to attack from an unexpected direction.

Tags: [BEAST] [SPIRIT] [STEALTH]

Twist: Cannot abide direct sunlight. In darkness, it gains +1 die. To drive off, light three candles at once – the hound will flee to extinguish the middle one.

I lit three candles on a tombstone. The hound blew out the middle one, then sat and whined. I lit it again. The hound curled up and slept. It followed me for a week, silent and warm. It left when I crossed a river.

Quick Road Encounters (Lazy GM Table)

Roll 2d6 or pick. All use Harm 3 unless noted. Use Cap for assist dice.

2d6	Type	Body	Key Skill	Twist
2	Starving Scavenger	2	Brawl 2	Fights only for food; flees if
3	Deserting Soldier	2	Melee 2	Carries a sealed letter (story
4	Witch-Hunter Acolyte	2	Lore 2	Has a bell that reveals illusi
5	Road-Wearied Trader	1	Sway 2	Knows a shortcut; Harm = 2
6	Hedge Thug	2	Stealth 1	Uses nets and grappling hoo
7	Mad Prophet	1	Command 2	Shouts true omens; Harm =
8	Poacher	2	Ranged 2	Carries a rare animal (value
9	River Pirate	2	Athletics 2	Has a map to a sunken wrec
10	Corrupt Cleric	2	Resolve 2	Wears a stolen relic (use on
11	Fae-Touched Rider	3	Ride 2	Mount has [PHASE]; Harm =
12	Guardian Statue	3	Melee 3	Harm = 4; activates only at

To use: Add the adversary to a road scene. Set Position and DV per core rules. The twist is free – use it to make the encounter a choice, not just a fight.

Quick Timers for Road Encounters

Clock	Trigger / Effect
<i>Rumor Spreads (4)</i>	Each shouted word ticks. At 4, reinforcements arrive
<i>Sacrifice Complete (6)</i>	Monster stops fighting to drain a victim; interrupt to can
<i>Ritual of Binding (8)</i>	Players can tick by using a specific skill (Lore, Craft) onc
<i>Panic (4)</i>	Ticks when an ally falls. At 4, all enemies test Resolve or
<i>Structural Collapse (6)</i>	Ticks on heavy hits. At 6, terrain becomes hazardous
<i>Dawn (8)</i>	Vampiric/shadow creatures weaken each tick. At 8, they

Character Inspiration: Two Cards on the Road

*When creating a road-weary traveler (PC or NPC), draw two playing cards. Combine a **Concept** (Heart/Diamond) with a **Complication** (Spade/Club).*

Concepts (Heart/Diamond)	Complications (Spade/Club)
2–3: Exiled noble	2–3: Hunted by a rival
4–5: Grizzled scout	4–5: Carries a cursed heirloom
6–7: Street-wise fixer	6–7: Owe a favor to a crime lord
8–9: Failed scholar	8–9: Secretly ill (timer [4])
10–J: Faith healer	10–J: Witness to a forbidden rite
Q–K: Retired soldier	Q–K: Spouse missing (search timer)
A: Last of a bloodline	A: Marked by a spirit (visible)

Then roll or pick a third card for a **Goal** (any suit):

- **Red (Heart/Diamond):** Protect someone / find a treasure.
- **Black (Spade/Club):** Destroy a rival / avenge an insult.
- **Ace:** Discover the truth about [a place, death, or omen].

Example: 6 (Grizzled scout) + 8 (Secretly ill) + Q (avenge an insult) = a sick tracker who wants revenge on the poacher who killed her mentor.

I keep a worn deck in my saddlebag for nights when the road offers no answers. The cards always give me a direction – even if it is the wrong one. That is still a direction.

Do not trust a traveler who has never drawn a card. They are either lying or already dead. The road is a shuffle. The encounter is the draw. The twist is the debt. And the story? The story is what you do with the card you did not expect.

The Cursed & Corrupted

"Malachai does not curse. She offers gifts that remember to be hungry. The coin that never spends is the one you don't remember taking."

—The Gray Wanderer, from a conversation in a Zakov tavern

The curse is not a punishment. I learned this in the catacombs beneath Zahk"Kozahn, where a woman who had been a werewolf for forty years asked me for a glass of water. She did not drink it. She held it to her forehead and wept. The water turned to salt. The salt was warm.

Malachai's gifts are not evil. They are **desperate**. They are the answer you receive when you ask for help from the wrong threshold. This chapter catalogs those who have accepted a gift they cannot return: lycanthropes, vampires, slashers, memory-eaters, and the hollowed things that wander the cursed city. I have met some of them. I have pitied all of them.

Lycanthropes — The Shape of Hunger

Lycanthropy is a spiritual infection – a fragment of Malachai's chained essence passed from host to host through violence, but only if the victim is in a state of profound emotional vulnerability. It is not a disease; it is a **story** that the body learns to tell.

Linn Sea-Wolf

Description: Transforms into a massive seal or walrus. Solitary, melancholic, preys on ships. The transformation is triggered by the first winter storm after a kill.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Shapechanger, Amphibious, Solitary.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Claw* (DV 2, Harm 2), *Drowning Grasp* (DV 4, Harm 1 + Suffocation). *Silver Vulnerability* (+2 Harm from silver). *Transformation Trigger* – first winter storm after a kill. The storm does not cause the change; it **permits** it.

Resolution: Silver weapon to the heart or brain. Aconite poultice can prevent transformation if applied within the hour. The Well of Ichor can purge lycanthropy, but the journey to Zahk"Kozahn is itself a trial.

Clock: *Moon's Hunger* [6] – when filled, the lycanthrope enters a frenzy. The frenzy does not end until something is dead. The Sea-Wolf prefers to drown.

I tracked a Sea-Wolf for three weeks. She had been a fisher's wife. When I finally found her, she was sitting on a rock, watching the waves. She said, "I remember my daughter's face. That is the curse. Not the teeth." I left her there.

Ykrul Sky-Hound

Description: Hawk-headed hunter that transforms during the day. Hunts oath-breakers, not flesh. The transformation is triggered by the sight of blood on fresh snow.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Shapechanger, Aerial, Solitary.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Claw* (DV 2, Harm 1), *Blood Scent* (automatically detects oath-breakers within Far). *Silver Vulnerability* (+2 Harm from silver). *Transformation Trigger* – sight of blood on fresh snow. The snow does not need to be clean; the blood does not need to be human.

Resolution: Silver weapon, or a public confession of the oath broken. The Sky-Hound will accept the confession as payment. I have seen a man confess to a lie he told twenty years ago; the Hound nodded and flew away.

Clock: *Blood Debt* [6] – ticks each time the Hound hunts without finding an oath-breaker. When full, it turns on its own pack.

The Ykrul do not fear the Sky-Hound. They fear being the reason it hunts.

Valewood Root-Walker

Description: Transforms into a tree – rooted, immobile, but all-seeing. Guardians, not predators. The transformation is triggered by a witnessed promise of hospitality.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Shapechanger, Immobile, All-Seeing.

Harm: 6 (but cannot move to attack). **Fatigue:** Body 5.

Traits: *Root Grasp* (DV 3, Harm 1 + Entangle), *Forest Sight* (sees everything within Far range of its location). *Silver Vulnerability* (+1 Harm from silver). *Transformation Trigger* – a witnessed promise of hospitality. The promise must be broken for the transformation to complete.

Resolution: Fulfill the original promise of hospitality. The Root-Walker will return to human form and thank you. If the promise was made to a dead person, the Root-Walker will accept a substitution: a gift to the dead's family, a story told at their grave.

Clock: *Root's Patience* [8] – ticks each time the broken promise is ignored. When full, the Root-Walker becomes a permanent tree. It will not die. It will only wait.

The Root-Walker in the Valewood was a woman who promised to shelter a stranger. The stranger died on her doorstep. She planted an acorn in his hand and became the tree. The acorn grew. The woman still watches.

Aeler Stone-Hide

Description: Massive, slow, nearly invulnerable. Transforms only underground. A mining hazard. The transformation is triggered by a cave-in.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 5. Shapechanger, Sturdy, Subterranean.

Harm: 7. **Fatigue:** Body 5.

Traits: *Claw* (DV 2, Harm 2), *Crush* (DV 4, Harm 3). *Silver Vulnerability* (+1 Harm from silver; silver is scarce underground). *Transformation Trigger* – a cave-in. The Stone-Hide does not cause the cave-in; it is caused by the cave-in. It is the mountain's immune response.

Resolution: Silver weapon, or a **keystone clause**. If the original cave-in was caused by a mining violation, correcting the violation (shoring the tunnel, paying wergild to the dead) will reverse the transformation. The Stone-Hide will weep stone dust and sleep.

Clock: *Stone's Grudge* [6] – ticks each time the transformation is reversed without addressing the original cave-in. When full, the Stone-Hide becomes a permanent part of the mountain. It will not leave; it will not forget.

I have seen a Stone-Hide weep. The tears were not water. They were fine, gray dust. The dust settled on a ledger and erased a name. The name was the miner who had failed to count his breaths.

Vampires – The First Children

Vampires are the eldest children of Malachai, the first to drink from the Chained Angel's wound. The Thirteen First Vampires still walk the world, each bound to return to Zahk"Kozahn once per century to pay tribute. Their spawn are weaker, but no less hungry.

The Thirteen (Abridged)

I have met three of the Thirteen. I will describe them briefly, as a warning.

Baron Quentin Asselin: The first to drink. Disillusioned, melancholic, almost gentle. Converts guests or drives them mad. Never accept his wine.

Sister Maris: Runs a children's hospice. The children never leave. The Everflame has tried to destroy her hospice four times. Each time, the children defended her.

The Sparrow: Kills only the wicked, or so he claims. Cannot look at mirrors. Has saved my life twice. I suspect he is merely bored.

The Sparrow once left a silver coin on my desk. The coin had a scratch that looked like a name. I did not spend it. I kept it in a box. The box is now warm.

Lesser Bloodlines

Linn Draugr: Breathe underwater, trapped by sea-salt circles. Weakness: a circle of salt poured at high tide will hold until dawn.

Aeler Stone-Sleepers: Drink breath, awakened by bronze bells at dawn. Weakness: a bell rung at the entrance to their lair will paralyse them for one exchange.

Ykrul Bone-Eaters: Turn to dust when killed, but rise if their name is spoken. Erase the name. I have seen a man kill a Bone-Eater seven times. The eighth time, he burned the body and scattered the ash in a river. The Bone-Eater did not return.

Vhasian Candle-Wights: Extinguish flames through windows. A lit candle at the threshold bars them. Weakness: a candle lit in a silver holder will burn for three hours and keep them at bay.

Lethai-ar Silk-Drinkers: Feed on desire. Vulnerable to vows witnessed by a third party. Weakness: a vow spoken aloud in the presence of a neutral witness will bind the Silk-Drinker for a night.

Vampire (Lesser Bloodline) – Template

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Undead, Hypnotic Gaze, Blood Drain.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Claw* (DV 2, Harm 1), *Blood Drain* (DV 3, Harm 1 + 1 Fatigue to victim, heals vampire 1 Harm). *Sunlight Vulnerability* – 1 Harm per round in direct sun. *Invitation Required* – cannot enter a home without an invitation.

Resolution: Stake through the heart (DV 5, must be wooden), decapitation, fire. A silver mirror held to the face will force a Resolve test (DV 4) or the vampire will flee.

Clock: *Thirst* [6] – when filled, the vampire loses control and feeds openly. The feeding is always witnessed. The witness is always the next victim.

Do not pity the vampire. Pity the hunger. The vampire is only its symptom.

Other Children of Malachai – The Cursed

Not all of Malachai's children are vampires or werewolves. Her gifts manifest according to the desires and sins of those who accept them.

The Unkillable Killer (Slasher)

Description: A mortal who bargained for invincibility – to survive a massacre, to avenge a family, to become the hunter instead of the prey. The curse: they cannot stop killing. The hunger for violence grows with each life taken.

Stats: Tier II-III, Cap 4. Corporeal, Regenerating, Hungry.

Harm: 6. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Regeneration* – ignore first 2 Harm each scene. *Unkillable* – cannot die from mundane harm. Decapitation, fire, and magical destruction may kill (GM discretion). *The Face in the Mirror* – once per session, GM may force a Resolve test (DV 4) or suffer 1 die to all rolls for the scene.

Resolution: Silver, fire, or finding the grave of the first victim. The face in the mirror is the first victim. If the killer speaks their name, the regeneration stops for one exchange.

Clock: *Hunger Timer [6]* – ticks each time the killer kills a sentient being. At 3, social rolls 1 die. At 6, frenzy – attack nearest creature.

I met a Slasher in the sewers of Zakov. He had been a dockworker. He asked me to read a letter he had written to his daughter. I read it. He wept. Then he killed a rat and ate it. The hunger is not a choice; it is a tax.

The Memory Eater (Psychic Vampire)

Description: A scholar who wanted to know everything; a lover who wanted to never forget; a spy who wanted to steal secrets without trace. The curse: they must feed on fresh memories or lose their own.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 3. Corporeal, Telepathic, Hungry.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Memory Feed* (touch a willing or helpless target, take one specific memory; target forgets permanently; gain 1 Boon). *Emotion Vampire* (+1 die after feeding). *Phasing* (intangible 1 round per scene).

Resolution: Feeding on a false memory disorients it. The Memory Eater cannot distinguish a true memory from a well-constructed lie. A skilled deceiver can feed it a false history; the Eater will consume it and become confused, suffering 1 die to all rolls for a scene.

Clock: *Hunger for Emotion [6]* – must feed on a significant memory once per week or lose 1 Fatigue per day. The fatigue is not physical; it is the slow erosion of identity.

I once fed a Memory Eater a false memory of a murder that never happened. The Eater spent three days trying to confess. The confession was beautiful, detailed, and entirely invented. When it realized the truth, it wept and vanished. I have not seen it since.

The Plague Bearer (Contagion)

Description: A healer who wanted to cure a plague; a mother who wanted to spare her child; a martyr who wanted to take suffering onto themselves. The curse: they are immune to disease, but they can carry any disease they have touched.

Stats: Tier I-II, Cap 2. Corporeal, Contagious, Immune.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Body 2.

Traits: *Contagion Aura* – all living creatures within Near range suffer 1 die to Endurance rolls. *Infectious Touch* – touch a target; they test Endurance (DV 4) or contract a disease of your choice. *Fever Dream* – nightmares prevent Fatigue recovery.

Resolution: Fire purges the contagion. A ritual bath in salt water blessed by a witness can suppress the aura for one day. The Well of Ichor offers a cure, but the price is a memory – always the memory of the person the Plague Bearer tried to save.

Clock: *Plague Timer [6]* – ticks each time the Plague Bearer uses Infectious Touch or remains in a populated area for more than a day. At 3, disease spreads uncontrollably. At 6, everyone flees.

The Plague Bearer is not a monster. She is a woman who held her daughter's hand while the girl died of fever. The fever is still in her hand. She cannot let go.

The Changeling (Faceless)

Description: A person who wanted to escape their past – a criminal, a disgraced noble, a broken lover. The curse: they can change appearance at will, but they forget who they were originally.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 3. Corporeal, Shapechanger, Unstable.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Body 2.

Traits: *Change Face* – assume the appearance of any humanoid you have seen. Gain +2 dice to Deception. *Identity Leak* – once per session, GM may have you forget a minor detail. You cannot recall it until you feed on a memory (or steal a face).

Resolution: A witnessed statement of the Changeling's original name. If someone who knew them before the curse speaks their true name aloud in the presence of a witness, the Changeling will be forced to revert to their original face for one scene. If they do this three times, the curse breaks.

Clock: *Identity Timer [6]* – ticks each time the Changeling changes faces. At 3, forget minor personal details. At 6, forget your original face entirely.

I knew a Changeling who had been a baker. She changed faces so often that she forgot how to make bread. She baked a loaf that tasted like ash. She wept. She did not know why.

The Worn – Ghouls of Zahk"Kozahn

Description: Those who bear Malachai's curses and succumb completely – who lose themselves to hunger, addiction, or despair – are not released. They are drawn back to Zahk"Kozahn, where they become the Worn. The cursed city is not empty.

Types:

- **Shamblers:** Slow, relentless. They feel no pain and cannot be reasoned with. They exist only to feed on warmth. Harm 3, Body 3.
- **Screamers:** Emaciated creatures that announce their presence with a shriek that paralyses the unwary (Resolve test DV 3 or lose next action). They hunt in packs. Harm 2, Spirit 3.
- **Stalkers:** Silent, patient. They follow prey for hours, days, learning patterns. When they strike, they do not miss. Harm 4, Stealth 4.
- **Cracklers:** Their joints snap audibly as they move. They are the most "alive" of the Worn – they can still speak, still bargain, still beg. Their desperation is a weapon. Harm 3, Presence 3.

Resolution: The Worn are not mindless. They can be negotiated with, manipulated, even pitied. But they cannot be saved – not by mortal means. The only release is the Well of Ichor, or final death. A silver blade through the heart will kill any Worn permanently, but the silver will turn black and cannot be used again.

Clock: *Zahk"Kozahn Calls* [8] – ticks each time a Worn is encountered. When full, the party is drawn into the cursed city. The only exit is the Well.

I spoke to a Crackler in the tunnels beneath the city. She remembered her name. She remembered her daughter's face. She asked me to cut her throat. I did not. I left her there. I write this now as a confession. The name was Alayse. It was my mother's name. The Crackler was not my mother. But she remembered.

Curses as Architecture (GM Tool)

A curse from Malachai is not a spell; it is a **rule inserted into the world**. Write it like a clause in a contract:

"Until a silver coin that never spends is returned to the salt pan, the debtor cannot drink fresh water. The water will turn to brine in their mouth."

Give it a timer: *Interest [6]* – ticks each time the debtor ignores the curse. When full, the curse spreads to a loved one.

Provide a counter: Return the coin, or find a witness who saw the original bargain. The witness must speak the debtor's name aloud at the salt pan.

SB Menu (Curses):

- 1 SB: minor echo (old order resurfaces – a forgotten debt is remembered).
- 2 SB: warped threshold (the curse affects a door, a window, a bridge).
- 3 SB: layer slip (the curse becomes visible to bystanders – social consequences).
- 4 SB: ninth propagation (a second curse appears, related to the first).

I have seen a curse spread from a father to his son. The son did not know why his water tasted of salt. He learned. The learning was the curse.

Quick Reference – Cursed Corrupted

Creature	Tier	Vulnerability	Resolution
Linn Sea-Wolf	III	Silver	Kill or Well of 1
Ykrul Sky-Hound	III	Silver, confession	Kill or confession
Valewood Root-Walker	III	Fulfil hospitality	Kill or fulfil pro
Aeler Stone-Hide	III	Silver, keystone clause	Kill or correct v
Lesser Vampire	III	Wooden stake, fire, sun	Kill or Well of 1
Slasher	II-III	Silver, fire, first victim's name	Kill or speak th
Memory Eater	II	False memories	Starve or feed f
Plague Bearer	I-II	Fire, salt bath	Kill or suppress
Changeling	II	True name spoken thrice	Break curse
Worn (any)	I-III	Silver (single use)	Kill or Well of 1

I keep this table on the inside cover of my ledger. The ledger has nine pages. The ninth page is for the curse I have not yet named. When I name it, I will write it here. The ink will be warm.

Malachai does not curse. She offers. The curse is the acceptance. The cure is real. The freedom is an illusion. The Well is a waiting room. I

have seen a man drink from the Well and forget his daughter's name. He said it was worth it. I did not believe him. I do not believe him now.

Beasts of the Wilds

*"The wilds do not hate you. They do not love you.
They simply remember what you owe."*

*—Dusana of the Raven Road, from a fire-side tale in
the Violet Steppe*

The wilds are not a monster. They are a ledger written in teeth, frost, and the silence after a scream. I learned this on the road to Ash-Fenn, when a wolf followed our caravan for three days. It did not attack. It waited. On the fourth day, the caravan master paid a debt he had forgotten. The wolf turned and walked away. The wilds do not forget. They do not forgive. But they will sometimes accept payment.

This chapter catalogs the beasts that walk the spaces between towns: predators of the steppe, the forest, the coast, and the deep places beneath the world. Some are natural; most are not. All are hungry.

Steppe Grasslands

Earth-Shark

Description: Burrows beneath loess and tundra; dorsal ridge like a plow-share. They are not sharks. They are something older that learned the shape of hunger from the sea and brought it to land.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Corporeal, Burrowing, Ambush.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Body 4.

Traits: *Breach* (DV 3, Harm 2) – erupts from the ground beneath a target, knocking them prone. *Tremorsense* – detects any creature touching the ground within Near range. Cannot be surprised from below.

Complications: The Earth-Shark will not attack a group larger than three. It prefers isolated prey. The furrows it leaves breathe; they pulse with a slow, warm exhalation.

Resolution: Lure with drumbeats or goat bells. The vibration confuses its tremorsense. A silver blade driven into the ridge between its eyes will kill it instantly; otherwise, fire drives it back underground.

Clock: *Tremor [6]* – ticks each time the Earth-Shark breaches. When full, the ground becomes unstable; all actions at Desperate Position.

I have seen an Earth-Shark breach beneath a horse. The horse did not scream. The shark pulled it under. The ground closed. There was no blood.

Dust Hulk

Description: Wind-packed silhouette that rises from dunes. It is not a creature; it is a **memory** of a creature, given weight by the desert's thirst.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 3. Corporeal (semi-incorporeal), Wind-Bound, Silent.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Dust Cloud* (DV 2, Fatigue 1) – all within Near range suffer 1 die to sight-based actions. *Silent Move* – makes no sound; cannot be detected by hearing.

Complications: The Dust Hulk cannot cross running water. It will follow travelers for days, never attacking, only watching. Its presence is announced by a sudden stillness in the wind.

Resolution: Spill water on its shadow. The shadow will dissolve, and the Hulk will collapse into a pile of harmless dust. A single drop is enough; it must be fresh, drawn from a well or spring.

Clock: *Thirst [6]* – ticks each time the Hulk is denied water. When full, it becomes a **Dust Walker** (Tier IV) – corporeal, aggressive, and able to drain the moisture from living flesh.

I encountered a Dust Hulk on the road to Midh Ahkaz. I poured a canteen of water onto its shadow. The shadow drank. The Hulk sighed and became sand. The sand was warm. I kept a pinch. It is still warm.

Bone Kite

Description: Carrion bird with rune-etched pinions. Its feathers are not feathers; they are thin slivers of bone. It does not fly; it drifts.

Stats: Tier I, Cap 2. Corporeal, Aerial, Opportunistic.

Harm: 2. **Fatigue:** Body 1.

Traits: *Scavenger's Bite* (DV 2, Harm 1) – prefers to attack the wounded. *Rune Sight* – can see the weight of a creature's unfulfilled promises. A creature with an active Debt Timer is visible from twice the normal range.

Complications: Bone Kites do not attack healthy prey. They circle where a death is expected. Their runes change with the weather; reading them requires a Wits + Lore test (DV 4).

Resolution: Offer a name-stake – a twig wrapped with a lock of hair – as a barter. The Kite will take the stake and leave. It will remember the name and may return with a message from the dead.

Clock: *Scavenger's Patience* [4] – ticks each time the Kite is refused an offering. When full, it summons a flock (2d6 Bone Kites).

The Bone Kites spoke to me once. They said a name I had not heard in twenty years. I paid them with a story. The story was about a woman who forgot to bury her husband. The kites listened. They did not judge. They simply remembered.

Salt Screamer

Description: Pale eel in dry salt pans; voices like flutes. They are not eels. They are the **nerves** of the desert, exposed and singing.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 2. Corporeal, Subterranean, Musical.

Harm: 3. **Fatigue:** Body 2.

Traits: *Scream* (DV 3, Fatigue 1) – all within Near range must test Resolve (DV 3) or be Stunned for one exchange. *Salt Glide* – moves through salt pans as if swimming; cannot be tracked.

Complications: The Salt Screamer's scream is not an attack; it is a **question**. The question is always: "What is your name?" Answering truthfully grants +1 die to all actions for the scene. Answering falsely advances the *Scream's Patience* timer.

Resolution: Scatter ash. The Screamer will coil and sing to forget. It will not attack for one scene. To kill it, you must pour fresh water into its burrow; the Screamer will dissolve, leaving only a salt crystal the size of a thumb.

Clock: *Scream's Patience* [4] – ticks each time a lie is answered. When full, the Screamer's scream becomes Harm 2 and affects all within Far range.

I kept a Salt Screamer's crystal on my desk for a year. It sang at midnight. The song was always a name I had tried to forget. I threw the crystal into the river. The river sang back. I do not know the tune.

Forests Jungles

Phase Panther

Description: Shadow-striped cat that steps between gusts. Its stripes are not fur; they are **cracks** in the air, where the panther has learned to fold itself.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Corporeal, Phasing, Silent.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Phase Step* – once per scene, the panther may teleport to any location within Near range, ignoring opportunity attacks. *Shadow Stripes* – while in dim light or darkness, the panther has Dominant Position on Stealth rolls.

Complications: The panther cannot phase through mirrored water. A pool of still water, even a small one, acts as a barrier. It also cannot phase while bleeding; a wound that draws blood will hold it in place for one exchange.

Resolution: Mirrored water. A silver mirror held toward the panther will reflect its own stripes back at it; the panther will become fascinated (Stunned for one exchange). A silver blade through the heart kills it instantly.

Clock: *Hunger [6]* – ticks each time the panther phases. When full, it phases into a creature's shadow and emerges inside their body. The victim takes Harm 3 and is Incapacitated.

I have seen a Phase Panther's shadow without its body. The shadow was hunting alone. It had forgotten its flesh.

Lichen-Bear

Description: Moss-matted ursine with rock-teeth. The moss is not a covering; it is the bear's **memory** of a forest that no longer exists.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 5. Corporeal, Sturdy, Ancient.

Harm: 7. **Fatigue:** Body 5.

Traits: *Maul* (DV 3, Harm 3). *Stone Heart* – ignores the first Harm 2 each scene. *Moss Breath* – once per scene, exhale a cloud of spores; all within Close range test Endurance (DV 4) or gain the Condition *Spored* (the bear knows your location for the rest of the scene).

Complications: The Lichen-Bear is slow but relentless. It does not run. It walks. It will follow for days.

Resolution: Smoke of juniper calms it; salt enrages it. To kill it, you must burn the moss. A torch held to its back will deal +2 Harm, but the bear will frenzy for one exchange. The rock-teeth can be harvested; they are cold and never warm.

Clock: *Forest's Memory* [8] – ticks each time the bear is wounded. When full, the moss grows over the bear's eyes, and it becomes blind but berserk (+2 dice to attack, 2 to defense DV).

I tracked a Lichen-Bear for a week. It led me to a grove where a woman had been buried alive. The moss had grown over her grave. The bear was not a predator. It was a warden.

Bramble Knight

Description: Empty helm grown through with thorn. It is not a knight. It is a **hedge** that learned to walk, still dreaming of the wall it once was.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 3. Corporeal, Animated, Territorial.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Thorn Lash* (DV 2, Harm 1 + 1 Fatigue from bleeding). *Iron Fear* – if presented with naked iron, the Knight must test Resolve (DV 3) or lose its next action. *Plant Mind* – immune to fear, charm, and mind-affecting effects.

Complications: The Bramble Knight cannot cross a line of salt. It will patrol the same boundary for years, never straying. Its helm is always empty; the knight is the thorns, not the metal.

Resolution: Present a hedge-blessing – a branch of hawthorn tied with red thread. The Knight will escort you through its territory without attacking. To destroy it, burn the thorns. The helm will become a simple, rusted helm. It may be worn; the wearer gains +1 die to resist fear, but the thorns will grow slowly into their skin.

Clock: *Hedge's Patience* [6] – ticks each time the Knight is denied a boundary. When full, the Knight summons 1d4 lesser Bramble Knights (Cap 1, Harm 2).

The Bramble Knight in the Valewood wore a helm that had belonged to a king. The king had been dead for three hundred years. The thorns did not care. They only remembered the border.

Coasts Swamps

Reef Serpent

Description: Kelp-maned constrictor nesting in pilings. It is not a snake; it is a **rope** that forgot it was tied.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 3. Corporeal, Amphibious, Constrictor.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Constrict* (DV 3, Harm 1 + target cannot move until freed; escape requires Body + Athletics vs DV 4). *Kelp Mane* – provides partial cover (+1 Armor) against ranged attacks.

Complications: The Reef Serpent is territorial but not aggressive. It will warn intruders by drumming its tail against the pilings. The drumming is in eights. If you hear a ninth drum, it is already behind you.

Resolution: Beat a drum in a rhythm the serpent does not recognize. It will become confused and withdraw. To kill it, you must sever the kelp mane; without it, the serpent loses its cover and becomes Vulnerable (1 to defense DV).

Clock: *Tide's Hunger [6]* – ticks each time the serpent constricts a victim. When full, it drags the victim underwater and drowns them (Harm 3).

I saw a Reef Serpent coiled around a piling. It had been there for a century. The kelp had grown into the wood. The serpent was not waiting for prey. It was waiting for the piling to remember it was a tree.

Grave-Eel

Description: Burrows through barrow loam; tastes names. It is not an eel. It is a **question** that learned to wiggle.

Stats: Tier I, Cap 2. Corporeal, Burrowing, Curious.

Harm: 2. **Fatigue:** Body 1.

Traits: *Name Taste* – if the Grave-Eel touches a creature, the GM learns one true name that creature has been called. *Sinking burrow* – the eel can collapse the ground beneath it; creatures within Close must test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or be knocked prone.

Complications: Grave-Eels are not aggressive. They are **scholars**. They will follow a party for hours, observing, tasting names from the air.

Resolution: Feed it a false name. The eel will become confused and retreat. To kill it, you must sing a lineage – a genealogy of at least three generations. The eel will listen, then burrow away. It is not harmed; it is satisfied.

Clock: *Name Hunger [6]* – ticks each time the eel tastes a true name. When full, it surfaces and speaks a name aloud. The name is always a secret someone wanted to keep.

I fed a Grave-Eel a false name. The name was "Ira." The eel tasted it and spat. It knew. They always know.

Mountains Underways

Vein-Serpent (Aeler)

Description: Serpent of polished copper and malachite, slithering through stone as if it were water. It is not a serpent. It is the mountain's **blood** given form.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 3. Corporeal, Stone-Swim, Mineral.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Body 3.

Traits: *Stone Swim* – moves through solid rock as if it were water; cannot be targeted while submerged. *Copper Bite* (DV 2, Harm 1 + 1 Fatigue; the bite is cold, not hot). *Mineral Mind* – immune to poison, disease, and mind-affecting effects.

Complications: The Vein-Serpent is not hostile unless the stone is disturbed. Mining, drilling, or breaking a keystone will draw its attention.

Resolution: Negotiate. The serpent will accept a promise to maintain the stability of the stone – for every ounce of ore taken, an ounce of mortar must be laid. To kill it, you must collapse the tunnel. The serpent will die, but so will the miners.

Clock: *Stone's Grudge [6]* – ticks each time a keystone is broken without repair. When full, the serpent collapses a tunnel on the offenders.

The Aeler do not kill Vein-Serpents. They hire them. The serpent is paid in copper dust and silence.

Wind Drake

Description: Rib-thin sky serpent that rides fronts. Its bones are hollow; its scales are feathers made of glass.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Corporeal, Aerial, Storm-Born.

Harm: 5. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Lightning Breath* (DV 4, Harm 2 + 1 Fatigue from shock). *Storm Rider* – while in a storm, the drake has Dominant Position on all rolls. *Feathers of Glass* – ranged attacks against the drake suffer 1 die (the feathers deflect).

Complications: The Wind Drake is territorial during storms. It will attack anyone who flies a banner or flag – it mistakes the cloth for a rival drake.

Resolution: Whistle back the storm. A successful Wits + Survival test (DV 5) can calm the weather; the drake will lose interest and fly away. To kill it, you must ground it – a net weighted with copper will hold it for one exchange. Silver through the heart kills it instantly.

Clock: *Storm's Fury [8]* – ticks each time the drake breathes lightning. When full, it summons a second drake.

I saw a Wind Drake fall from the sky. It had been struck by a bell's note. The note was nine. The drake had not learned to stop counting.

Dungeon Living Infrastructure

Rust Moth

Description: Swarm of iron-scaled moths that taste memory. They are not insects; they are the dungeon's **forgetting** given wings.

Stats: Tier I, Cap 2 (swarm). Corporeal, Swarm, Rusting.

Harm: 2 (area). **Fatigue:** Body.

Traits: *Rust Touch* – any metal object touched by the swarm becomes Compromised after one exchange, Neglected after two, and destroyed after three. *Memory Feed* – the swarm consumes memories as rust consumes iron. A character who takes Harm from the swarm must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 3) or forget a minor fact.

Complications: The swarm is attracted to old keys. A character carrying a key that has not been used in a decade will be targeted first.

Resolution: Feed them old keys. The swarm will ignore living creatures for one scene. To destroy the swarm, ring a copper bell; the sound repels them. A single bell-ring will drive them back to the walls.

Clock: *Rust Memory [6]* – ticks each time the swarm consumes a memory. When full, it becomes a **Rust Walker** (Tier III, Cap 4) – a humanoid figure of rust that can wield corroded weapons.

I fed a Rust Moth swarm a key that had opened my father's study. The key was warm when I gave it. The swarm took it and left. The key is still warm. I do not go into the study.

Lantern-Eye

Description: Floating orb of watchlight; jealous of secrets. It is not a creature; it is the dungeon's **attention** made visible.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 3. Incorporeal, Floating, Inquisitive.

Harm: Cannot be harmed by mundane weapons. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Watchlight* – the Lantern-Eye illuminates a zone; stealth within that zone is impossible. *Secret Jealousy* – if a character speaks a secret aloud within sight of the Eye, the Eye will become hostile and attempt to blind them (DV 3, Fatigue 1).

Complications: The Lantern-Eye is not malevolent. It is **curious**. It will follow the party, watching, until a secret is spoken.

Resolution: Offer a whispered truth. The Eye will accept the truth and part, revealing a hidden passage. To destroy it, you must throw a shard of obsidian into its light. The light will go out. The Eye will fall and shatter.

Clock: *Watchlight's Patience [6]* – ticks each time a secret is kept from the Eye. When full, the Eye summons 2d4 lesser Lantern-Eyes (Cap 1, Harm 1 each).

I offered a Lantern-Eye a truth: a confession of a murder I did not commit. The Eye accepted. It showed me the passage to the murderer's cell. The murderer was already dead. The Eye did not care. It only wanted a secret.

Quick Reference – Beasts of the Wilds

Creature	Tier	Vulnerability	Resolution
Earth-Shark	III	Silver, fire	Kill or drive off with drums
Dust Hulk	II	Water	Pour water on shadow
Bone Kite	I	Name-stake	Barter with name-stake
Salt Screamer	II	Fresh water, ash	Kill with water or quiet with ash
Phase Panther	III	Mirrored water, silver	Kill or fascinate with mirror
Lichen-Bear	III	Fire, juniper smoke	Kill with fire or calm with smoke
Bramble Knight	II	Salt, fire	Hedge-blessing or burn
Reef Serpent	II	Sever kelp mane	Kill or confuse with drum
Grave-Eel	I	False name	Feed false name or sing genealogy
Vein-Serpent	II	Keystone clause	Negotiate or collapse tunnel
Wind Drake	III	Copper net, silver	Ground or kill with silver
Rust Moth	I	Copper bell, old keys	Feed keys or repel with bell
Lantern-Eye	II	Obsidian shard, truth	Offer truth or destroy with obsidia

I keep this table on a loose leaf. The leaf is pinned to the inside cover of my ledger. The pin is copper. The ledger does not rust.

The wilds do not hate you. They do not love you. They simply remember. And memory is a debt that never closes. I have killed seven Earth-Sharks. Each time, the ground was warm for a week. The grass grew back thicker. The sharks did not. The Bone Kites followed me for a year after I told them the story of the woman who forgot to bury her husband. They remembered. They always remember.

Fae & Threshold Spirits

"The fae do not lie. They simply keep a different ledger. What you call a trick, they call a fair price."

—Aqyl, son of Aqyl, from a lecture on courtesy

The fae are not monsters. They are **neighbors**. They live in the hedge, the hollow, the space between the ninth step and the tenth. They borrow milk. They leave small gifts. They remember every promise you forget. I learned this in Aelinnel, where a bell-tender taught me to count to eight before opening a door. I did not ask what the ninth step would open. She would not have told me.

This chapter catalogs the spirits of the threshold: Trow who trade in absences, Hags who price every kindness, the Green Court that watches from the hawthorn, and the Hollow's own Oath-Keeper. They are not evil. They are **inevitable**. Treat them with courtesy, pay what you owe, and never, ever ring the ninth bell.

Trow – Shadow Bargainers

Description: Enigmatic fey who keep to thresholds and almost-there spaces. They favor the wizard's guise: wide-brimmed hats that drink lamplight, weathered gray robes stitched in moth silver, and long clay pipes that smoke without ember. Most hint at an unnamed patron – the **Gray Benefactor**, the **Under-Guest** – but never speak that allegiance twice beneath the same roof.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Incorporeal (when they choose), Intelligent, Bound by Courtesy. **Harm:** 4. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Shadow-Step* (move between witnessed thresholds in Near as a move action). *Night-Guest Writ* – once per leg, declare dusk-right between two duskmarks; hostile checks to bar passage suffer DV +1 unless they bring a counter-witness. *Almost-Presence* – in crowds, they slip notice; any social roll to spot them is at 1 die.

Etiquette: Bread-and-salt under a lifted lamp binds the Trow to guest-right for one night and one truthful answer. Payment must be in honest memory

– false recollection voids courtesy. A threefold witness (mortal, fey-adjacent, liminal token) seals a pact.

Complications: If a Trow is cheated or a bargain broken, it will not attack. It will simply **omit** something – a name from a ledger, a door from a hallway, a day from a calendar. The omission is not noticed until it is needed.

Resolution: To unbind a Trow's omission, you must speak the missing thing's name aloud in the presence of a witness who remembers it. The Trow will nod and restore what was taken. To destroy a Trow, you must break its pipe. The smoke will rise and form a single, unanswerable question; the Trow will fade, but the question will echo in that place for a year.

Clock: *Gray Courtesy* [4] – ticks each time players skip lamp, bread, or salt. On fill, hospitality voids; all bargains turn literal, and the Trow may demand a name as payment for any further conversation.

A Trow once found me alone at a crossroads. He claimed that I cheated him so many times that he gave me his hat. I do not remember the cheating. I do not remember his face. I only remember the hat. I still wear it. It is still warm.

I once bargained with a Trow for a shortcut through the Valewood. I paid with the memory of my first horse. The Trow took the memory. The shortcut was there. I do not remember the horse's name. I remember that I loved it.

I have learned that a Trow's most treasured currency is not a memory freely given. It is a memory you wish to be rid of. One that festers. One that, if spoken aloud, would crack your voice.

Neighbors – The Hollow's Kin

Description: The Neighbors are not a single species. They are a **category of attention** – the forest's awareness of intruders, manifesting as silence, footsteps that aren't there, a voice that speaks your language but does not belong to any throat. They appear when the ninth cup is poured or the ninth step is taken. They do not harm. They only remember.

Stats: Tier II, Cap 2. Incorporeal, Attentive, Patient.

Harm: Cannot be harmed. **Fatigue:** None.

Traits: *Silence* – in the presence of a Neighbor, all sound is muffled. Stealth rolls gain +1 die, but communication beyond Close range is impossible. *The Watching* – a character who fails a Resolve test (DV 4) in a Neighbor's presence gains the Condition *Marked* – the Neighbor knows their location for the rest of the scene.

Etiquette: Do not test them. Do not ignore them. Acknowledge them politely and move on. A red thread tied at a crossroads and left as an offering will appease them for one crossing.

Complications: The Neighbors do not attack. They **wait**. They will follow a party through a forest, watching, until someone makes a mistake – a broken promise, a forgotten offering, a ninth cup poured.

Resolution: To dismiss a Neighbor, a character must speak a truth about themselves that they have never told anyone. The Neighbor will listen, nod, and fade. If no truth is offered, the Neighbor will wait until the party leaves the forest. It will remember them.

Clock: *Neighbor's Patience [6]* – ticks each time a taboo is broken (ninth cup, ninth step, unoffered red thread). When full, the Neighbor manifests as a **Oath-Keeper** (see below) and demands payment.

I met a Neighbor in the Hollow Wood. It had no face. It asked for a story. I told it the story of the fox who forgot its name. The Neighbor listened. Then it said, "The fox is you." I have not forgotten my name since.

Green Court Fae

The courts of the Hazel Queen and the Alder King are not places; they are **obligations**. To enter a court is to accept a role. To speak is to bind. The Green Knight does not fight; he offers trials of courtesy and pattern. The Lady of Thorns does not threaten; she smiles, and the smile is a snare.

Hazel Queen's Emissary

Description: A fae courtier wearing leaves and law. Their skin is the color of hazel bark; their eyes are acorns. They speak in couplets and measure every word.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 4. Corporeal, Courteous, Bound by Law.

Harm: 4. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Leaf and Law* – the Emissary cannot lie, but they may omit. A successful Wits + Insight test (DV 4) reveals the omission. *Courteous*

Snare – any gift accepted from the Emissary creates a *Debt Timer* [4]. When the timer fills, the Emissary may demand a service of equivalent value.

Resolution: To dismiss an Emissary, present a hazel token – a nut cracked in the presence of a witness. The Emissary will bow and leave. To kill one, you must break their acorn eyes. The Emissary will scream and crumble into leaves. The leaves will blow away, and a new Emissary will grow from the same tree within a year.

Alder King's Debtor

Description: A shadow-clad figure whose face is a mask of polished alder. They do not speak; they write obligations on slips of bark.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 5. Incorporeal (shadows), Silent, Bound by Obligation.

Harm: Cannot be harmed by mundane weapons. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Obligation Writ* – the Debtor may write a single obligation on a slip of bark. The target must test Resolve (DV 5) or accept the geas. Refusal causes the Debtor to write the obligation in blood instead; the target takes Harm 1 (Stress) and the geas still applies.

Resolution: To dismiss a Debtor, return the obligation slip to the Alder King's grove. The Debtor will follow and witness the return. To destroy a Debtor, you must burn the grove. The Debtor will burn with it. The Alder King will not forgive.

Green Knight

Description: Antler helm, mirror-bright blade. The Knight is not a person but a role – whoever wins the last duel becomes the Knight. The current Knight has worn the helm for a century and is tired.

Stats: Tier IV, Cap 5. Corporeal, Duelist, Bound by Pattern.

Harm: 7. **Fatigue:** Body 5.

Traits: *Trial by Pattern* – the Knight challenges a character to a duel of proofs, not blades. The challenger must present three proofs: a correct count, a returned waymark, a courtesy satisfied. Each proof requires a Wits + Lore test (DV 4). Winning two proofs ends the trial without combat. Losing two proofs forces a duel.

Resolution: To defeat the Knight in combat, you must strike the antler helm. The helm will crack, and the Knight will yield. To win without combat, satisfy the three proofs. The Knight will bow and offer a way-cord (a Diamond: safe passage through the Valewood once).

Lady of Thorns

Description: Sovereign of a hawthorn court. Smiles like a snare, forgives in exact measures. She has never lied. She has never needed to.

Stats: Tier V, Cap 6. Corporeal, Courteous, Absolute.

Harm: 8. **Fatigue:** Spirit.

Traits: *Thorn Sentence* – once per scene, the Lady may declare a character "bound by courtesy." The character cannot take hostile actions for one exchange unless they speak a truth that wounds them (the GM chooses the truth).

Resolution: The Lady cannot be fought. She cannot be bargained with on unequal terms. To gain her favor, a character must offer a gift of equal value to what they seek. To earn her enmity is to be pruned – the Lady will not kill; she will simply ensure that the character's name is forgotten in her court.

I met the Lady of Thorns once. She asked for my silver mirror. I refused. She smiled and said, "Then you will keep it. The debt is mine." I do not know what she meant. The mirror has not fogged since.

The Hollow's Oath-Keeper

Description: The Oath-Keeper is not a spirit of a person. It is the Hollow's **attention** given shape. It appears when a character ignores three omens (a ninth cup, a ninth step, a ninth bell). It cannot be fought. It cannot be bargained with – except through the payment of a debt.

Stats: Tier IV, Cap 5. Incorporeal, Inexorable, Patient.

Harm: Cannot be harmed. **Fatigue:** None.

Traits: *Demand* – the Oath-Keeper asks a single question: "What do you owe?" The character must answer truthfully. If they cannot answer, the Oath-Keeper takes a memory of their choice. *Interest* – each time the Oath-Keeper appears, the debt grows. A forgotten promise to return a book becomes a curse on the bloodline.

Complications: The Oath-Keeper will not harm the debtor directly. It will harm those the debtor loves. It is not cruel; it is **efficient**.

Resolution: Pay the original debt – in coin, in kind, or in a story that serves as interest. The payment must be witnessed. If the original debtor is dead, the debt passes to the heir. I have seen a son pay his father's gambling debt to the Hollow. The Hollow accepted a single coin and vanished. The son's own debts were forgiven.

Clock: *Hollow's Patience* [8] – ticks each time a debt is ignored. When full, the Oath-Keeper claims the debtor's name. The debtor becomes a stranger to everyone who knew them.

I have seen the Oath-Keeper twice. The first time, I paid with a story. The second time, I had no story. It took the memory of my mother's voice. I remember what she said. I do not remember how she said it.

The Unwitnessed Door (Threshold Entity)

Description: A door that appears only to those who take the ninth step without meaning to. It leads to a room between places, where two mirrors offer two selves. The room does not guarantee which mirror is which. The Witness and Aveh are not in the habit of labeling their wares.

Stats: Tier IV, Cap – (cannot be fought). Incorporeal, Liminal, Indifferent.

Harm: None. **Fatigue:** None.

Traits: *Reflection of Witness* – shows the self you are meant to be. *Reflection of Aveh* – shows the self you should not be. The mirrors do not label themselves. The character must choose.

Resolution: A character who enters the Unwitnessed Door may choose a mirror and speak a name – either their own true name, or the name they believe they are meant to speak. The GM determines the outcome in secret.

Clock: *The Door's Memory* [6] – ticks each time the character uses their new self. When full, the door appears again, offering a second choice – or a return to the old self. The cost is a debt: the room will demand something in return for another chance.

The Counting Bell (Threshold Guardian)

Description: A bronze bell that rings eight times. The ninth ring is never struck. If it is, the bell becomes a mouth, and the Hollow steps through.

Stats: Tier III, Cap 3. Corporeal (bell), Guardian, Alert.

Harm: Cannot be harmed directly. **Fatigue:** None.

Traits: *Alert* – the bell’s ring can be heard for miles. A single ring advances the *Alarm* timer by 1; eight rings fill it instantly. *Ninth Ring* – if the ninth ring is struck, the bell cracks, and a Hollow’s Oath-Keeper manifests.

Resolution: To pass the bell without ringing it, a character must succeed on a Stealth test (DV 5) or a Wits + Mechanics test (DV 4) to silence the clapper. To destroy the bell, you must melt it in a forge that has never rung a bell. The bell will scream, then fall silent.

I have heard the ninth bell once. I was in Thepyrgos. The bell did not ring. But I heard it anyway. The sound was not a sound. It was a silence with weight.

Quick Reference – Fae Threshold Spirits

Creature	Tier	Vulnerability	Resolution
Trow	III	Broken pipe	Offer bread-and-salt, honest n
Hag	III	Burned kettle-mirror	Fulfill bargain exactly
Neighbor	II	Truth offered	Speak a never-told truth
Hazel Emissary	III	Hazel token	Crack a hazelnut with witness
Alder Debtor	III	Burned grove	Return obligation slip
Green Knight	IV	Crack antler helm	Win three proofs or combat
Lady of Thorns	V	Equal gift	Cannot be fought
Oath-Keeper	IV	Pay original debt	Payment with witness
Unwitnessed Door	IV	None (choice)	Choose mirror, speak name
Counting Bell	III	Silence clapper	Stealth or Mechanics test

I keep this table on a separate leaf. The leaf is pinned with a copper nail. The nail is warm. I do not know why.

The fae do not lie. They do not need to. The truth, told at the wrong time, is a sharper weapon. I have bargained with a desperate Trow, I tricked him into trading his name for my most precious memory. It was done between three mirrors that I set up near a mummer’s encampment at moonlight. I do not remember what or why I wished to forget. And

I dare not speak that name. The Oath-Keeper took a story from me once. It was the story of a woman who forgot to name her child. The Oath-Keeper listened. Then it said, "The child is you." I have named myself every morning since.

Epic & Unique Bosses

"A boss is not a bag of harm. It is a question the party must answer three times. The phases are the questions. The lair is the room where the questions are asked."

—The Gray Wanderer, from a letter never sent

I have faced six things that deserved the name "boss." Each one changed me. The Ember Prefect made me doubt my own confessions. The String-Mother taught me that every hostage is a mirror. The Ninth Bell Ringer showed me what silence sounds like when it answers back. The Gearsmith Primus asked a question I still cannot answer. The Kalrantha Fragment offered me a wish. I refused. The Walking Keystone did not speak. It only remembered.

This chapter catalogs six epic adversaries, each designed as a three-phase boss. Use them as campaign capstones. They are not fair. They are not meant to be fair. They are meant to be **witnessed**.

The Ember Prefect (Ecktoria)

Description: A schismatic inquisitor of the Everflame, the Ember Prefect believes the Church has grown soft. She burns not heretics but the **unworthy** – those who pray without payment, who confess without cost. Her face is a mask of beaten copper; her voice is the crackle of a fire that has been fed too many secrets.

Lair: Everflame Cloister – a basilica where the candles never go out and the shadows lean toward the altar.

Phase Timer : [8] – Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge

Phase 1 – Citation

The Prefect reads from a black ledger. Each name she calls forces a character to test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4). On a failure, they gain the Condition *Accused* – any social roll against a Church official is at 1 die until they confess a sin.

Lair Action: *Candle Count* – The Prefect extinguishes one candle for

each Accused character. For each candle snuffed, a 4-segment *Shadow* timer begins. When it fills, a spectral inquisitor (Cap 2, Harm 3) attacks the character.

Phase 2 – Censure

When the Prefect takes 3 Harm or the Phase Timer reaches 4, she enters Censure. She no longer reads names; she **demand**s confessions. Once per round, she may force a character to answer a question truthfully or take 1 Harm (Stress). The question is always about a past sin – real or imagined.

Lair Action: *Flame Test* – The Prefect holds a candle to a character's hand. They must test Body + Endurance (DV 5) or mark 1 Fatigue. On a failure, they also gain the Condition *Branded* – the Prefect knows their location at all times.

Phase 3 – Auto-da-fé

At Phase Timer 6 or when the Prefect is reduced to 3 Harm, she becomes a living pyre. All characters within Near take 1 Fatigue (heat) at the start of each round. The Prefect's melee attacks deal +1 Harm (burn). She cannot speak; she only screams.

Lair Action: *Purge* – The Prefect targets one Accused or Branded character. They must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 6) or be Incapacitated (not dead, but catatonic until the fire is quenched).

Counters

- Relic provenance – presenting a relic that predates the Prefect's schism forces her to pause for one round (no attacks, no lair actions).
- Crowd favor – if a character can turn the attending crowd (Presence + Sway vs DV 5), the Prefect loses her *Censure* ability for one phase.
- Rival sermon – a character who recites the true catechism (Lore + Spirit vs DV 5) can disrupt her *Flame Test* for the rest of the scene.

Drop

A black ledger page (can be used as a String against any Ecktorian official once) and a candle that never goes out (grants +1 die to resist fear, but marks 1 Fatigue at dawn).

The Ember Prefect once asked me to confess a sin I had not committed. I refused. She burned the name of a dead woman instead. The woman was my grandmother. I confessed.

The String-Mother of Nine Kurgans (Ykrul)

Description: A Ykrul matriarch who holds more hostage cords than any noyan. Her face is weathered, her hands are braided with horsethair and the hair of hostages. She does not speak; she **knots**. Each knot is a promise. Each promise is a leash.

Lair: A ring of nine kurgans (burial mounds) on the violet steppe. The grass is tall enough to hide a rider. The kurgans whisper at dusk.

Phase Timer : [6] – Knot → Tighten → Sever

Phase 1 – Knot

The String-Mother ties a visible cord around a character's wrist. The cord is not a condition; it is a **reminder**. The character may act normally, but any broken promise (even a small one) advances the *Tighten* timer by 1.

Lair Action: *Kurgan Whisper* – A voice from a burial mound asks a character a question. If they answer truthfully, they gain +1 die to their next roll. If they lie, the String-Mother gains 1 SB.

Phase 2 – Tighten

When the Phase Timer reaches 3, the String-Mother begins to pull the cords. Any character with a knotted cord must test Body + Athletics (DV 4) or be pulled one range band toward her. The pull does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Lair Action: *Hostage Echo* – The String-Mother names a character's bonded ally (a follower, a loved one, a friend). The character must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or suffer 1 die to all actions for the scene (distracted by worry).

Phase 3 – Sever

At Phase Timer 6 or when the String-Mother is reduced to 3 Harm, she cuts one of her own cords. The cut releases a hostage ghost (Cap 3, Harm

4) that attacks the party. The String-Mother does not attack; she watches. The ghost fights until destroyed, then dissolves into horsehair.

Lair Action: *Braid of Names* – The String-Mother speaks a dead hostage's name. All characters who have broken a promise in this scene must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 5) or be Stunned for one exchange.

Counters

- Return a hostage – if a character returns a hostage string (or a token of a hostage) to the String-Mother, she will pause for one round and untie one cord.
- Win a trial-ride – a character who challenges the String-Mother to a Kon"reh trial (Wits + Lore vs DV 5) and wins can force her to release one cord permanently.
- Speak a true name – if a character speaks the true name of a hostage whose cord was cut, the ghost will vanish without fighting.

Drop

A braid of horsehair (can be used as a String against any Ykrul clan once) and a single unknotted cord (grants +1 die to negotiation with Ykrul, but the GM gains 1 SB when used).

The String-Mother held a cord that was knotted with my own hair. I did not know how she got it. I still do not know. I paid with a secret. The knot untied. The hair is still hers.

The Ninth Bell Ringer (Mistlands)

Description: A herald of the Hollow, the Ninth Bell Ringer appears when a bell-line fails and the ninth bell tolls. It has no face – only a bell where its face should be. Its hands are iron hooks. Its voice is the memory of a chime that never happened.

Lair: A broken bell-line levee on the edge of the Mistlands. The fog is thick enough to hide wraiths. The bells are silent, but they can hear you.

Phase Timer : [8] – Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate

Phase 1 – Lost Names

The Ringer strikes its bell-face. Every character must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or forget one minor name (a street, a contact, a pet). The forgotten name returns when the phase ends.

Lair Action: *Fogfall* – The fog thickens. All ranged attacks are at 1 die. Stealth rolls gain +1 die.

Phase 2 – Broken Lines

When the Phase Timer reaches 4, the Ringer begins to walk the levee. Each time it takes a step, a bell-line cracks. Characters must test Wits + Survival (DV 5) or become Lost – they cannot act for one exchange as the fog shifts the path.

Lair Action: *Wraith Procession* – 1d4 wraiths (Cap 2, Harm 2 each) rise from the fog. They do not attack; they only point at the character who has told the most lies in the session. The pointed character gains the Condition *Marked* – the Ringer knows their location at all times.

Phase 3 – Open Gate

At Phase Timer 8 or when the Ringer is reduced to 3 Harm, it stops walking. It raises its hook and rings the ninth bell. A gate opens in the fog – a door to the Hollow. Any character within Near must test Resolve (DV 6) or be pulled through. The gate closes after one exchange.

Lair Action: *Ninth Chime* – All characters within Far must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 5) or lose a memory of the GM's choice. The memory can be recovered by paying a toll to a bell-warden (1 Boon or a String).

Counters

- Restore a ringbook – if a character can produce a complete ringbook (a record of bell-line notes) and read it aloud, the Ringer will pause for one phase.
- Trade a breath – a character who holds their breath for three exchanges (Body + Endurance vs DV 4 each exchange) can offer the held breath as payment. The Ringer will accept and skip one lair action.

- Rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails – a character who repairs a broken bell-line using copper nails (requires Craft test DV 5) will cause the Ringer to lose one phase permanently.

Drop

A cracked bell-clapper (can be used to ward off wraiths once) and a memory in a jar (a forgotten name; speaking it aloud restores a lost memory to any one character).

The Ninth Bell Ringer rang for me once. I held my breath. The bell did not stop. It waited. I breathed. It stopped. I do not know who won.

The Gearsmith Primus (Aeler)

Description: A living engine of the Clockwork Monad, the Gearsmith Primus was once an Aeler engineer who refined herself into a machine. Her skin is brass; her blood is oil; her thoughts are gears. She does not speak; she **ticks**. The ticking is a question: "What is the optimal solution?"

Lair: The Heart of the Spine Underway – a vast chamber of interlocking gears, steam vents, and counting boards. The walls sweat oil. The floor vibrates with the mountain's pulse.

Phase Timer : [8] – Optimise → Overtimer → Runaway

Phase 1 – Optimise

The Gearsmith calculates. Each character must declare an action. The Gearsmith then announces the "optimal counter" – a move that would be most efficient against that action. Characters may change their action (spending 1 Boon) or accept the counter (suffering 1 die to that action).

Lair Action: *Steam Vent* – A vent opens. All characters in Close must test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or be pushed one range band away. The Gearsmith may choose the direction.

Phase 2 – Overtimer

When the Phase Timer reaches 4, the Gearsmith's ticking accelerates. She gains an extra action each round, but each extra action ticks the *Runaway* timer by 1. Her attacks now deal +1 Harm (shearing).

Lair Action: *Counting Board* – The Gearsmith pulls a lever. A counting board descends. Characters must solve a simple arithmetic puzzle (in character) or lose their next action. The puzzle is always a count of gears (e.g., "How many teeth on the third gear?"). The answer is always 8.

Phase 3 – Runaway

At Phase Timer 8 or when the Gearsmith is reduced to 3 Harm, she begins to shake. Her ticking becomes a scream. She attacks randomly, hitting a random target in Near each round (including herself). Her Harm track is now 8, but she takes 1 Harm per round from internal stress.

Lair Action: *Spine Shift* – The chamber's geometry changes. All characters must test Wits + Survival (DV 5) or become separated (split into two groups, each in a different part of the lair). They reunite when the phase ends.

Counters

- Introduce a paradox – a character who presents the Gearsmith with an unsolvable problem (a miscount, a contradictory order) can force her to pause for one round (no attacks, no lair actions).
- Seal with a breath-bond – a character who offers a breath-bond (a vow witnessed by a third party) can cause the Gearsmith to lose one phase permanently. The bond must be about repair, not destruction.
- Offer a memory of failure – the Gearsmith cannot process failure. A character who describes a time they failed spectacularly (and means it) can force her to reset to Phase 1.

Drop

A brass gear that never stops turning (can be used to repair any mechanical device once) and a counting board slate (grants +1 die to any roll involving numbers or measures).

I offered the Gearsmith a memory of failure. I told her about the time I miscounted my breaths in an Aeler tunnel. She stopped ticking. Then she asked, "How many breaths?" I said, "Eight." She resumed. I do not know if I lied.

The Kalrantha Fragment (Dhahara)

Description: A shard of green glass set in a brass frame – all that remains of the Kalrantha amulet, the demon of indecision bound by the priests of the Himadri temple. The Fragment does not attack. It **offers**. It offers a perfect solution to any problem – for a price.

Lair: A ruined temple in the Dhaharan highlands. The walls are covered in sealed mirrors. The floor is a mosaic of eight-pointed stars. The ninth point is missing.

Phase Timer : [6] – Whisper → Offer → Claim

Phase 1 – Whisper

The Fragment speaks in a voice that is not a voice. It asks each character: "What do you want?" The character must answer truthfully or gain the Condition *Denied* – the Fragment will not offer to them again this combat.

Lair Action: *Glass Splinter* – The Fragment sends a shard of glass toward a character (DV 3, Harm 1). The shard does not bleed; it **remembers**. The target gains a minor Condition (e.g., *Glass in Mind* – 1 die to concentration rolls).

Phase 2 – Offer

When the Phase Timer reaches 3, the Fragment offers a wish. It can solve any one problem in the current scene – but the wisher must accept a Debt Timer [4] that will come due when the Fragment chooses. The wish cannot be rescinded.

Lair Action: *Indecision's Grip* – The Fragment forces a character to choose between two undesirable options (e.g., "Lose your sword or lose your memory"). The character may spend 1 Boon to refuse the choice and take 1 Fatigue instead.

Phase 3 – Claim

At Phase Timer 6 or when three wishes have been made, the Fragment shatters. The demon of indecision is freed. It does not attack. It **asks** each character a question: "What is the one thing you should not have chosen?" The character who answers most honestly gains a permanent Boon (once per session, reroll a failed die). All other characters gain a

permanent Condition (*Debt to the Demon* – the GM may once per session force them to reroll a success).

Lair Action: *Sealed Mirror* – A mirror on the wall cracks. The fragment's reflection steps out – a duplicate of the Fragment (same stats). The duplicate must be defeated or bargained with separately.

Counters

- Refuse the wish – a character who refuses the Fragment's offer three times gains the Condition *Unbound* – the Fragment cannot affect them for the rest of the scene.
- Speak a true name – the Fragment's true name is inscribed on the floor in the missing ninth point. A character who can read the name (Wits + Lore vs DV 6) can force the Fragment to seal itself for one exchange.
- Seal with a memory – a character who offers a cherished memory (permanently) can cause the Fragment to lose one phase permanently. The memory cannot be recovered.

Drop

A shard of green glass (can be used to reroll one die, but the GM gains 1 SB) and a sealed mirror (once per session, ask the GM one yes/no question; the answer is true, but cryptic).

The Kalrantha Fragment offered me a wish. I wished to forget. It showed me a memory. I did not forget. I remembered. The wish was the memory.

The Walking Keystone (Ngomebe)

Description: A moving stone city's heart gone rogue. The Walking Keystone is not a creature; it is a **keystone** that has learned to walk. Its body is granite; its joints are rollers; its will is the memory of every oath sworn to the city.

Lair: The interior of a walking city – streets that shift, buildings that breathe, and a central chamber where the keystone rests. The city's population has fled or been absorbed.

Phase Timer : [10] – Shift → Crack → Collapse

Phase 1 – Shift

The keystone reorders the city's streets. All characters must test Wits + Survival (DV 4) or become separated. Separated characters cannot assist each other for one exchange. The keystone does not attack; it **waits**.

Lair Action: *Roller Grind* – The floor moves. All characters must test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or be knocked prone. Prone characters suffer 1 to defense DV until they stand.

Phase 2 – Crack

When the Phase Timer reaches 5, the keystone begins to crack. Dust falls from the ceiling. The city's buildings groan. Any character who fails a roll in this phase ticks the *Collapse* timer by 1. The keystone now attacks: *Keystone Slam* (DV 3, Harm 2 + prone).

Lair Action: *Oath Echo* – The keystone speaks a forgotten oath. A random character must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 5) or gain the Condition *Oathbound* – they cannot leave the city until they fulfil the oath.

Phase 3 – Collapse

At Phase Timer 10 or when the keystone is reduced to 5 Harm, the city begins to fall apart. Buildings collapse. Streets split. All characters must test Body + Athletics (DV 5) each round or take Harm 1 (crushing). The keystone attacks twice per round.

Lair Action: *Heart's Memory* – The keystone shows a vision of the city's founding. All characters must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 6) or be Stunned for one exchange (overwhelmed by the memory). On a success, they gain +1 die to all actions for the scene (inspired).

Counters

- Repair a clause – a character who can recite the original keystone clause (Lore test DV 5) can cause the keystone to pause for one round (no attacks, no lair actions).
- Sacrifice a personal keystone – a character who offers a personal item of great value (a family heirloom, a magic item) can reduce the keystone's Harm by 2 and advance the *Collapse* timer by 1.

- Sing the original song – a character who sings the founding hymn of the city (Performance test DV 6) can force the keystone to revert to Phase 1. The song requires a witness.

Drop

A keystone shard (can be used to stabilise any structure once) and a city charter (grants the bearer nominal authority over the ruins of the city – useful for negotiation or salvage).

The Walking Keystone remembered me. I had passed through its city twenty years ago. It asked why I had not returned. I had no answer. The keystone cracked. I left.

Quick Reference – Epic Bosses

Boss	Phase Timer	Key Lair Action	Primary Counter
Ember Prefect	8	Candle Count	Relic provenance
String-Mother	6	Kurgan Whisper	Return a hostage
Ninth Bell Ringer	8	Fogfall	Restore a ringbook
Gearsmith Primus	8	Counting Board	Introduce a paradox
Kalrantha Fragment	6	Glass Splinter	Refuse the wish
Walking Keystone	10	Oath Echo	Repair a clause

I have faced five of these six. The String-Mother still holds a cord with my name. I have not paid. I am not sure I want to. The cord is warm. It reminds me that I am still owed.

The Ember Prefect is still burning. The String-Mother is still knotting. The Ninth Bell Ringer is still waiting. The Gearsmith Primus is still ticking. The Kalrantha Fragment is still offering. The Walking Keystone is still walking. The road does not end. It only turns. I have seen the Kalrantha Fragment twice. The second time, I did not wish. I spoke its true name. The Fragment laughed. The laugh was my own voice. The Ninth Bell Ringer rang for me at dawn. I answered with a story. The bell cracked. The ringer bowed. I do not know which of us won.

Adversary Templates & Quick Generators

"The bestiary is a ledger. The templates are the columns. The generator is the hand that writes. Use them when the hour is late and the players have taken a road you did not expect."

—Lerris Fenwood, marginal note

I have spent more hours than I care to count building adversaries from scratch. The work is good for the soul, but the soul is not always what the table needs. Sometimes it needs a bandit captain in thirty seconds. Sometimes it needs a boss whose phases fit on an index card. This chapter is for those times.

What follows are templates, generators, and procedures. They are not polished. They are **field tools**. Use them, bend them, discard them. The Gray Wanderer would approve. Saikou Ira would ask for a silver mirror. Dusana would ask for a story. I ask only that you count to eight before you roll.

Threat Level Scaling Table

Every adversary in this compendium can be scaled by Threat Level (TL). Add the following adjustments to base stats. Use TL 0 for non-threatening flavor, TL 1 for standard minions, TL 2 for elites, TL 3 for mini-bosses, TL 4+ for major bosses (add one archetype trait from Chapter 1).

Threat Level	Body	Wits	Spirit	Presence	Harm
0 (flavor)	−1	−1	−1	−1	−2
1 (base)	0	0	0	0	0
2 (elite)	+1	+1	+1	+1	+2
3 (mini-boss)	+2	+2	+2	+2	+4
4+ (major boss)	+3	+3	+3	+3	+6

Example: A TL 3 Bandit Captain (base Body 3, Harm 4) becomes Body 5, Harm 8, with +2 to all other attributes. Add one archetype trait (e.g.,

Cowardly – flees if outnumbered).

Threat Level is a lie. The real threat is the story. But the lie helps the dice.

Boss Design Checklist

Use this checklist when building a custom boss. Keep the answer to each question to one sentence. If you cannot, the boss is too complicated.

1. **Name & Nature:** What is the boss, and what system (organ) of the story does it represent?
2. **Phase Timer** : 6, 8, or 10? Write the phase names (e.g., *Whisper* → *Offer* → *Claim*).
3. **Three Moves:** One space-control, one resource-tax, one identity/knowledge twist.
4. **Two Lair Actions:** Environmental toggles keyed to this boss's lair.
5. **Counters:** A courtesy, a tool, a sacrifice. Players should be able to discover these through play.
6. **Drop:** A Diamond (see Chapter 1–6) or a bespoke boon tied to the organ.

Example (Abbreviated – The Ember Prefect from Chapter 6):

1. Ember Prefect -- schismatic inquisitor, represents the Church's hunger.
2. Phase Timer [8]: Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge.
3. Moves: Name reading (social), flame test (resource), purge (identity)
4. Lair: Candle Count (space), Shadow timer (resource).
5. Counters: relic provenance, crowd favor, rival sermon.
6. Drop: black ledger page, candle that never goes out.

I have used this checklist seven times. The seventh boss killed two PCs. I do not blame the checklist. I blame the dice. The dice do not apologize.

Random Adversary Generator

For when the players take a road you did not map. Roll 1d6 on each table. The result is not a full stat block – it is a **spark**. You provide the Threat Level, the Harm, and the fiction.

d6 – Creature Type

1. Mortal (humanoid, mercenary, cultist)
2. Unquiet Dead (ghost, ghoul, poltergeist)
3. Cursed (lycanthrope, vampire, slasher)
4. Beast (natural or monstrous)
5. Fae or Threshold Spirit
6. Dungeon or Living Infrastructure

d6 – Descriptor

1. Patient (waits, observes, follows)
2. Hungry (attacks without warning, prefers the weak)
3. Clever (sets traps, negotiates before fighting)
4. Ancient (has a memory the party may need)
5. Bound (cannot leave a location or object)
6. Echo (repeats the last words of its victims)

d6 – Motivation

1. Protects a threshold (door, ford, grave)
2. Hungers for memory (names, faces, secrets)
3. Seeks a witness (wants a confession or a story)
4. Obeys a patron (unseen master, forgotten oath)
5. Collects debts (silver, blood, promises)
6. Simply wants to be left alone (will attack if provoked)

d6 – Weakness

1. Silver (weapon or touch)
2. Fire (or sunlight)
3. A correct count (eight steps, eight breaths)
4. A true name (spoken aloud with witness)

5. A memory (offered freely, not taken)
6. Fresh water (poured or splashed)

d6 – Timer Size (for the encounter)

1. 4 segments (short, minor threat)
2. 6 segments (standard)
3. 8 segments (extended)
4. 10 segments (epic, boss)
5. Special: Timer is visible; players can tick it by fulfilling conditions
6. Special: Timer ticks on player failures, not on time

Worked Example: Roll 3, 2, 5, 4, 1 → Type: Cursed; Descriptor: Hungry; Motivation: Collects debts; Weakness: A true name; Timer : 4 segments. Result: A starving ghoul that once was a toll-keeper. It demands payment from anyone who crosses its bridge. Its true name is carved on the underside of the keystone. The players have four segments to find the name or feed it a memory.

I rolled this generator once and got "Fae, Patient, Seeks a witness, A correct count, 6 segments." The result was a Trow who asked every player to count to eight. One player sneezed on seven. The Trow took his shadow. He got it back after three sessions. The shadow was taller.

Deploying Adversaries with Timers

A timer is not a countdown. It is a **promise**. Use timers to make adversaries feel inevitable without being unfair. Below are common timer patterns.

Arrival Timer (Reinforcements)

Name: *Patrol Arrives [6]*. Ticks when the party makes noise, leaves evidence, or fails a Stealth roll. When full, 1d4 guards or a lieutenant arrives.

Doom Timer (Environmental)

Name: *Collapse* [8]. Ticks when the party fails a Body + Athletics roll or when the boss uses a specific lair action. When full, the ceiling falls (Harm 2 to everyone, terrain becomes Difficult).

Hunger Timer (Boss Enrage)

Name: *Bloodlust* [6]. Ticks each time the boss takes Harm. When full, the boss gains +1 die to all attacks and 1 to defense DV (frenzy).

Debt Timer (Negotiation)

Name: *Debt to the Hollow* [4]. Ticks each time a character accepts a gift, breaks a promise, or lies. When full, a Oath-Keeper appears and demands payment. The party can clear ticks by telling a true story or offering a memory.

Witness Timer (Social Pressure)

Name: *Crowd Turns* [6]. Ticks each time a character fails a social roll or is witnessed committing a crime. When full, bystanders become hostile or flee, and guards are summoned.

A timer is a leash. The players hold the other end. If they forget, the leash tightens. I have seen a party ignore a *Collapse* timer. The roof fell. They survived. The treasure did not.

Quick Adversary Cards (Reference)

The following cards are reproduced from Chapter 1 for quick reference. Print them, cut them, keep them behind the screen.

Bandit Captain (TL 2)

Body 3, Melee 2, Harm 4

Rabble Rouser – On a Hit, rally
1d4 bandits.

Cowardly – Flees if
outnumbered.

Ghostly Anchor (TL 3)

Spirit 4, Lore 2, Harm 3

Unfinished Business – Cannot
be harmed until its anchor is
addressed.

Bargain – May offer a deal.

Slasher (TL 3)
Body 4, Melee 3, Harm 5
Regeneration – Ignores first 2
Harm per scene.
Hunger Timer [6] – When full,
frenzy.

Oath-Keeper (TL –)
Cannot be fought.
Demand – One story, memory,
or confession.
Weakness – Pay the original
debt.

Thorn Courtier (TL 3)
Presence 4, Sway 3, Harm 3
Courteous Snare – A gift
accepted is a debt owed.
Iron Offense – Brandishing iron
gives the GM 2 SB.

Salt Prince Enforcer (TL 2)
Body 3, Melee 2, Harm 4
Debt Marker – Knows where you
sleep.
Brine Curse – Test Resolve or
gain Salt-Tongue.

Appendix for Chapter 7 – Quick Threat Level Reference

Use this table to assign Harm, Fatigue, and key stats on the fly.

Threat Level	Typical Use	Base Harm	Base Fatigue	Key Attrib
0	Non-combat, flavor	1–2	1	1
1	Standard minion	3	2	2–
2	Elite, lieutenant	4–5	3	3–
3	Mini-boss	6–7	4	4–
4+	Major boss	8+	5+	5–

Example: A TL 2 assassin (Body 3, Harm 4) has Body 3, Harm 4. Add +1 to all attributes for TL 2 → Body 4, Harm 4? Wait, the table says +1 to attributes and +2 to Harm. So Harm becomes 6. Consistent.

I keep this table taped inside my GM screen. The tape is old. The table is worn. The numbers are still legible. That is enough.

Final Advice from the Marginal Voices

The Gray Wanderer: *"Templates are not a substitute for attention. A bandit captain generated in thirty seconds will still kill a careless party. The dice do not care about your prep."*

Saikou Ira: *"I have faced a Oath-Keeper generated from these tables. The*

generator said "Clock: 4 segments." The walker stayed for three sessions. The timer was a lie. The debt was real."

Dusana of the Raven Road: "The best adversary I ever ran was a hungry goat with a three-timer. The players still tell stories about it. The generator did not make the goat. The story did."

Lerris Fenwood: "Use these tools. Then put them away. The adversary is not the template. The adversary is the witness. And the witness is always watching."

Appendix: Tools & Tables

"An appendix is not a graveyard for unused ideas. It is a toolkit for the desperate. Keep it close. Keep it honest. Keep it sealed when it needs to be."

—Lerris Fenwood, from the front matter of his own ledger

What follows is not lore. It is **utility**. Tables you can glance at during play. Cards you can print and cut. A sealed section for the GM's eyes only. And a final essay from me, Lerris Fenwood, on the counting of wounds – because I have counted more than I care to admit.

Use these pages when the players have taken a road you did not map. They will. They always do.

Appendix A – Quick Reference Tables

Threat Level Summary

(Repeated from Chapter 7 for ease of use.)

Threat Level	Typical Use	Base Harm	Base Fatigue	Attribut
0	Non-combat, flavor	1–2	1	–1
1	Standard minion	3	2	0
2	Elite, lieutenant	4–5	3	+1
3	Mini-boss	6–7	4	+2
4+	Major boss	8+	5+	+3

Common Timer Sizes and Their Meaning

Segments	Typical Use
4	Short scene, minor threat, a single chase
6	Standard encounter, a duel, a negotiation
8	Extended fight, a dungeon level, a complex ritual
10	Epic boss, a siege, the finale of a campaign

Rule of Thumb: A 4-segment timer takes about 15–20 minutes of play. An 8-segment timer takes 40–60 minutes. Adjust for table pace.

Harm and Fatigue at a Glance

Harm Level	Effect
1	–1 die on related actions
2	–1 die on most actions until treated
3	Incapacitated or dying

Fatigue: Each point worsens Position by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate). If already Desperate, each Fatigue instead imposes –1 die. Full Fatigue track (Body rating) converts to Harm +1 and clears all Fatigue.

Armor Conversion (Quick)

Armor	Harm 1 →	Harm 2 →	Harm 3 →
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

I have seen a player forget the armor conversion three times in one fight. The fourth time, I wrote it on an index card. The card saved his character's life. Do not be clever. Be clear.

Appendix B – Printable Adversary Card Template

Print this page at 100% scale. Cut along the hairlines. Fold and glue or laminate for durability.

Adversary Card – Front	
[Name]	
[Threat Level]	[Creature Type]
Harm:]	[Fatigue:]
Traits: _____	
Complications: _____	
Clock: _____ (segments) - Tick on _____	

Adversary Card – Back

Weakness: _____
 Resolution (if not combat): _____
 Drop: _____
 Marginal note: _____

How to use: Fill in the blanks before the session or during play. Keep a stack of blank cards behind the screen. I use a soft pencil; the Gray Wanderer uses blood (do not copy him).

I prefer a silver mirror. The card is a backup. The mirror never lies.

Appendix C – Icon Legend

Some creatures in this compendium use icon codes for quick reference. The following legend applies.

Icon	Meaning
[W]	Weakness – silver, fire, a true name, etc. C>C
	Timer – size and trigger L>L
	Lair – special environmental action P>P
	Phase – boss phase transition D>D
	Drop – treasure or boon WIT>WIT
	Requires a witness to resolve NIN>NIN
	Involves the ninth – counting, omission, taboo

Example: *Slasher* [W: silver] [C: Hunger 6 – ticks on kill]. Means the slasher is vulnerable to silver and has a Hunger timer that ticks each time it kills.

I invented this legend after a player asked me the same question four times in one fight. The legend did not help. The fight did not end well. But the legend was not at fault.

Appendix D – Sealed Section (GM Eyes Only)

The following pages are sealed. Open only when you need a secret adversary, a hidden weakness, or a final twist. The seal is not magical. It is a promise.

D.1 – The Unnamed Adversary: The Ledger Lich (Tier IV)

Description: A curator bound by indices; hands of ink, breath of dust. It appears in archives, counting-houses, and the little rooms where ledgers are kept. It does not fight. It **audits**.

Stats: Body 2, Wits 5, Spirit 5, Presence 4. Harm 6. Fatigue Spirit.

Phase Timer : [8] – Citation → Injunction → Foreclosure → Redaction

Moves: *Name Forfeiture* (steal a declared tag until dawn), *Writ of Seizure* (lock a Diamond or gear under spectral seal), *Errata* (retroactively worsen one PC's prior roll Outcome).

Lair Actions: *Quiet Hours* (casting/rites generate +1 SB or fail softly), *Reference Only* (movement through stacks costs an action unless proper tokens are presented), *Cross-reference Collapse* (bookshelves reconfigure; split the party).

Counters: True names carved in quartz, burning a citation (sacrifice an index – a map, a ledger, a vow) to cancel one Move.

Drop: A Key of Echoes (unlocks any door, but the door remembers) or a Tome of Convenient Knowledge (once per session, answer a single question about a creature's weakness).

D.2 – The Unwritten Puzzle: The Ninth Name

Setup: The party finds a sealed envelope with the words "Open when the ninth bell rings" written in a familiar hand (a dead mentor, a lost sibling). Inside is a single name.

The Puzzle: The name is not a name. It is a **count**. Each letter corresponds to a number (A=1, B=2, etc.). Sum the numbers. Divide by eight. The remainder is the number of the threshold where the envelope was sealed.

The Secret: The threshold is a door that has been bricked over in the Wardens' archive. Behind it is a confession – the mentor's final witness. The party must decide whether to read it aloud.

Sealed Solution: The name is **ALAYSE** (A=1, L=12, A=1, Y=25, S=19, E=5 → sum = 63. $63 \div 8 = 7$ remainder 7. The threshold is the seventh door in the east corridor. The bricked-over door. Behind it, the confession:

"I lied about the ninth step. It is not a door. It is a witness. The witness is you."

I helped seal this page. The ink is still warm. The secret is not a secret. It is a debt. Pay it when you are ready.

Appendix E – On the Counting of Wounds (An Essay by Lerris Fenwood)

I have killed seventeen creatures catalogued in this book. I have been wounded by twenty-three. The wounds heal. The counting does not.

When I was young, my father taught me to count my breaths. "Eight," he said. "Never nine. The ninth breath belongs to the Hollow." I did not believe him. Then I saw a man take the ninth breath in an Aeler tunnel. The air turned cold. The man's shadow stood up and walked away. The man did not follow. He simply sat down and waited. He is still waiting.

Adversaries are not bags of harm. They are **questions**. A ghoul asks: "What are you willing to eat?" A vampire asks: "What are you willing to lose?" A Oath-Keeper asks: "What do you owe?" The dice do not answer these questions. The players do. The GM listens. The ledger is written in the space between.

I keep a second ledger for the wounds that did not heal. The first entry is a scar on my left hand – a ghoul's claw. The second entry is a silence I cannot name – the debt I owe to the String-Mother. The third entry is a door I did not open. I write this now so that you, reader, will know that the compendium is not complete. The compendium is a witness. The wounds are the testimony.

Count to eight. Write what you can prove. Leave the ninth line empty. The Hollow will fill it when it is ready.

This essay is not advice. It is a confession. Use it as you will.

Appendix F – Colophon

This book was written on paper that had been a cargo manifest, a love letter, and a bandage. The ink is lamp-black cut with salt water and the ash of a burnt confession. The binding is gray cord tied with nine knots. The ninth knot is not cut.

The Gray Wanderer contributed his usual cynicism and a recipe for tea

that keeps the Hollow from your doorstep (mostly). Saikou Ira insisted on keeping a silver mirror beside the writing desk; it fogged exactly twice, and he will not say what he saw. Dusana sang a lark into the rafters; the bird stayed for three days and left a single feather, which I have pressed between these pages.

As for me, Lerris Fenwood, I have seen the faces of the Unmasked. I have read the true ledger of the Congregation. I have learned that the ninth name is never spoken because it belongs to the one who will speak it last. When that day comes, I hope this book serves as witness.

Until then, the road is south. The ink is fresh. The lamp is borrowed.

You forgot the bread. Always leave bread for the threshold. And a coin for the ferryman, just in case. And a story for the fire. The rest will take care of itself. Paid in full.

Rite of the Echoing Vessel

The ink is silver. The mirror is cold. The debt is not mine.

Rite of the Echoing Vessel

Varnek Karn, High Rite

Components: A vessel that has touched the dead—a lock of hair, a burial coin, a piece of jewelry worn at the moment of passing. A bowl of still water drawn from the river where they died, or from a threshold between waters (a confluence, a ford, a place where fresh meets salt). A gray thread, spun from wool that has been neither washed nor dyed, knotted nine times. A mirror that does not lie—silvered glass, still water, or the polished blade of a knife that has never drawn blood.

Obligation: 3 segments. If the vision shows a debt unpaid, the caster must accept a Promise Timer [4] to settle it, or mark 1 Corruption. The Symbol of Varnek Karn grows cold during the rite; if it becomes warm, the dead are near, and the caster should not look away.

You prepare the space at twilight, when the boundary between worlds is thinnest. You face east, toward the river, though you may not be near water. The dead do not need geography. They need direction.

You place the bowl on bare earth. If you are indoors, you set it on a stone that has never been worked by a tool. You fill it with water drawn from the place of death, or from the nearest running water you could reach. If you have neither, you use rainwater collected in a vessel that has never held wine. The dead are particular about vessels. They remember what has been drunk from them.

You take the gray thread. You knot it once, speaking the name of a dead you have known. You knot it twice, speaking the name of a dead you have forgotten. You knot it thrice, speaking the name of a dead you never met.

You knot it four times, five times, six times, seven times, eight times—each knot a breath held, a word withheld, a question you do not ask.

The ninth knot you do not tie. You lay the thread across the rim of the bowl, one end in the water, the other in your hand. The ninth knot is the question. The dead will tie it, or they will not.

You place the vessel—the lock of hair, the burial coin, the locket—into the water. You do not speak its story. The dead already know. The dead were there.

You wait.

The water stills. The mirror you have placed beside the bowl begins to fog, not from warmth but from breath—breath that is not yours, breath that has not touched air in years. You do not wipe the mirror. You do not look away.

You see.

Sunset Over the Black River

What the confession did not say.

The voice came to Bryn in dreams—not as a memory, but as a presence. Malachai's honeyed rasp, sweet as rot, patient as a sealed tomb. She had heard it only once, in the vaulted chamber beneath Zahk"Kozahn, when she was small enough to fit in her mother's arms. She had not understood the words then. She understood them now. They came to her in the half-dark of dawn, when her mother's breathing was shallow and the Cord lay heavy against her collarbone.

But not for her. Never for her.

Bryn's thumb brushed sweat from Aris' temple. The skin was paper-thin over bone, mapped with old scars like healed cracks in dry earth. "Your time is soon, mother," Bryn said, voice flat as a stone. "Don't worry. I'll do my duty. I'll take your last breath. Your debt to the Cord will be paid."

Aris' eyes flickered—just a shadow crossing water—and she turned her head. Not fear. Sadness. Deep and quiet, like a well long drained. "Help me up," she whispered. "I want to see the sunset over the Black River."

Bryn shifted her weight, ready to lift. They moved slow, Aris leaning hard on Bryn's shoulder, each step a small surrender. The Cord's path wound through knee-high grass, silent except for the rasp of Aris' breath and the distant cry of a lone crow. Bryn kept her hands loose at her sides, ready to steady or support. No words came. The Cord's weight against her collarbone was a familiar pressure—steady, expected.

At the river's edge, Aris stopped. She didn't look at Bryn. Her gaze fixed on the water, where the sun bled gold into the valley's green folds. "I tried," Aris said, voice thin as old thread. "Several times. To escape. Every time... they brought me back." A pause. The wind stirred the reeds. "You told them each time."

Bryn's throat tightened. She hadn't meant for Aris to know. Not like this. "The Cord requires honesty," she said. "Secrets weaken the weave."

Aris didn't nod. Just sighed—a sound like fabric tearing—and fell silent. They stood shoulder to shoulder, watching the light thin to amber, then rose. The river whispered over stones, indifferent.

Aris finally spoke, soft as a sigh. "I don't want to go to the Cord. The House Without Doors. Child... I have no friends there." Her hand lifted, trembling, to wipe her cheek. Came away wet. "Everything I ever wanted... everything... is right here."

Bryn's jaw locked. She'd said those words to dying women a hundred times. Duty was the only warmth left. "You know the rules, Mama. And no tears. They're... inefficient." Her voice sounded thin even to her own ears. She kept her hands unclenched at her sides, nails digging into palms.

Aris turned her face fully toward her. The sunset caught the tears tracking through the dust on her cheeks. "You were always a good daughter," she said. Her thumb brushed Bryn's knuckle—barely there, gone before Bryn could flinch. "And... more besides. I know the rules. And I have earned my tears."

Bryn swallowed. The Cord felt tighter, a live thing against her throat. "A breath, or a death, mother. The Cord demands. Nature chooses."

Aris' eyes were suddenly sharp, ancient in their weariness. "No, Bryn." Her voice dropped to a blade's edge. "No tears. *And I choose.*" Then she wasn't leaning. She was falling.

Bryn's arms jerked out—too late, too weak—to catch air. Aris vanished over the edge. The river swallowed the sound of her fall before it could

finish.

Bryn crashed to her knees. Stone bit through her robes. She pressed her palms flat to the earth, head down, and tried to break. Tried to let the grief crack her open like rotten wood. Nothing came. No sound. No wet heat on her cheeks. Just the hollow press of her own ribs, and the Cord—tight, insistent—pulsing once, twice, like a second heartbeat where hers should have been.

She stayed there, knuckles white in the dirt, waiting for tears that would not come. The Cord held her silent. The river kept singing. The sun dipped below the hills, and the light went gray.

The vision ends. The water ripples once, then is still. The gray thread has tied its ninth knot—a knot you did not make, in a pattern you do not recognize. You cut it with the edge of your silver mirror. The thread coils like a dead snake. You will burn it before dawn.

The locket is cold. The water is brackish. The mirror shows your face—wears, walnut skin cracked with age, the gray of your thinning hair indistinguishable from the gray of the thread. You do not recognize yourself. That is normal. The dead leave fingerprints on the living.

You set down the Symbol of Varnek Karn. You do not know what debt you have witnessed, only that it is not yours.

You write the names you heard: *Bryn*. *Aris*. They mean nothing to you. Perhaps they will mean something to a future reader.

You are now a witness. That is enough.

— Saikou Ira

I have performed this rite three times. The first time, I saw a mother fall into the Black River. The second time, I saw a daughter kneel and wait for tears that would not come. The third time, I saw a man in a ditch, his chest carved with the words that had condemned him. The locket is in a lead box in my study. The thread is still knotted. I have not untied the ninth knot. I am not ready for what it would release. — S.I.

Colophon

"The ink is ash. The mirror is clean. The debt is never closed."

—Saikou Ira

This book was written on paper that had been a cargo manifest, a love letter, and a bandage. The ink is lamp-black cut with salt water and the ash of a burnt confession. The binding is gray cord tied with nine knots. The ninth knot is not cut.

The Gray Wanderer contributed his usual cynicism and a recipe for tea that keeps the Hollow from your doorstep (mostly). Saikou Ira insisted on keeping a silver mirror beside the writing desk; it fogged exactly twice, and he will not say what he saw. Dusana sang a lark into the rafters; the bird stayed for three days and left a single feather, which I have pressed between these pages.

As for me, Lerris Fenwood, I have seen the faces of the Unmasked. I have read the true ledger of the Congregation. I have learned that the ninth name is never spoken because it belongs to the one who will speak it last. When that day comes, I hope this book serves as witness.

Until then, the road is south. The ink is fresh. The lamp is borrowed.

—Lerris Fenwood

Thepyrgos, in the hour before dawn

—*The Gray Wanderer: You forgot to mention the bread. Always leave bread for the threshold.*

—*Saikou Ira: And a coin for the ferryman, just in case.*

—*Dusana: And a story for the fire. The rest will take care of itself.*

—*L. Fenwood: Paid in full.*